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AI in managerial decision-making:

A qualitative exploration of cross-regional attitudes in a global tech company

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Abstract

This thesis explores how managers in a global tech company engage with Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) in their daily decision-making and whether attitudes toward AI vary across regions. Using a comparative qualitative design, nine managers within the same function across three regions participated in semi-structured interviews that combined Likert-scale statements and open-ended questions. The study integrates TAM2 with theories of bounded rationality and intuitive decision-making to propose a combined framework, capturing both rational technology evaluations and cognitive realities of managerial judgment. The results show that managers consistently use AI as an augmentation tool rather than a decision-maker: it supports data-intensive or time-pressured tasks but requires verification, as trust is conditional. Perceived Usefulness (PU) drives adoption, while Perceived Ease of Use (PEOU) remains modest due to prompting effort. Regional differences reflect perceived output quality; Region 2 reports high PU and usage despite low PEOU, whereas skepticism persists in Region 3. Across all regions, managers maintain firm boundaries around people-related or ethically sensitive decisions, where human intuition and contextual experience prevail. Alongside the empirical insights, the thesis makes a central contribution through the combined theoretical model, offering a conceptual foundation for future research on AI-supported decision-making in organizations.

Keywords: Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI); decision-making; bounded rationality; intuition; Technology Acceptance Model (TAM2); human-AI interaction; international business

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1. Introduction

1.1 Background

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has rapidly evolved from a specialized area of computer science to a mainstream technology that shapes many aspects of daily life and business. In simple terms, AI refers to computer systems that are able to perform tasks that require human-like intelligence, such as learning, reasoning and problem-solving. The influence of AI continues to expand at an accelerating rate, with 2025 numbers suggesting a US$244 billion market size (Marr, 2025). The value of the global industry for AI tools and services is predicted to rise to US$1 trillion by 2031 (Marr, 2025). This rapid growth reflects not only the growing computational power and access to large-scale data, but also the inflow of investment and changes to how organizations view AI. According to Stanford University (2025), 78% of organizations reported using AI in 2024.

In organizations, AI can enhance decision-making by complementing or improving analytical abilities, increasing productivity and reducing human error. A McKinsey report shows that AI adoption in organizations can significantly improve the efficiency of decision-making and overall performance of organizations (Singla et al., 2025). When organizations couple senior leadership oversight with workflow design and embed AI into business processes, these organizations begin to generate meaningful bottom-line impact (Singla et al., 2025). Thus, the growing implementation of AI is fundamentally reshaping organizations across all industries. This has profound implications for managers who are actively involved in organizational decision-making processes.

However, achieving the full potential of AI depends not only on its implementation at the organizational level but also on its effective use and acceptance by employees. According to a survey from the European Central Bank, while the adoption of AI among large European firms is relatively high – 75% report using AI in their daily business operations – the actual usage at the employee level remains limited (Bergeaud et al., 2025). On average, only one in four employees actively engages with AI tools in their work. This gap between organizational adoption and employee utilization suggests that realizing the efficiency gains promised by AI requires greater emphasis on workforce readiness, digital literacy and cultural acceptance of AI technologies (Bergeaud et al., 2025).

The topic holds high societal relevance, as AI is increasingly integrated into daily and global professional life. Examining similarities and differences in AI usage and acceptance across various geographical settings can provide valuable insights into how cultural and other contextual factors may shape technology adoption. Such understanding can help companies adapt their communication strategies, practices and implementation guidelines to local conditions and cultural attitudes. In this way, organizations can more effectively promote a positive attitude toward AI and thereby create better conditions for successful implementation.

1.2 Problem description

Researchers have long examined how decisions are made within organizations, focusing on how to improve efficiency, reduce bias and address common challenges in decision-making processes. Over time, various theories have emerged to explain how individuals make choices and process information, which has shaped our understanding of organizational decision-making. These studies highlight that decision-making is not always perfectly rational but is influenced by cognitive limitations (e.g. Simon, 1979; Kahneman, 2011), contextual factors and organizational structures. This body of research has laid the foundation for much of today's understanding of how organizations make and implement decisions.

At the same time, AI introduces a new dimension to decision-making. As organizations increasingly start to use AI tools, these systems are already influencing how decisions are made, both at the individual and organizational level (Singla et al., 2025). This shift has significant implications for how we understand professional behavior and the dynamics of decision-making within modern organizations. In recent years, research exploring the relationship between AI and decision-making has grown, focusing on how AI technologies affect organizational structures, efficiency and outcomes in practice.

Recent research suggests that AI offers opportunities to enhance efficiency in decision-making (e.g. Menzies et al., 2024; Prasanth et al., 2023), improve decision speed (Kubatko et al., 2024) and support strategic decision-making under uncertainty (Trunk et al., 2020), but also raises concerns related to trust and control (Leyer & Schneider, 2021), ethical implications and data privacy (Kourkoumelis et al., 2024; Kubatko et al., 2024; Prasanth et al., 2023), and organizational resistance (Menzies et al., 2024). It is also commonly emphasized that AI should augment rather than replace human judgment, given its lack of

empathy and contextual understanding (Jarrahi, 2018; Vincent, 2021; Kourkoumelis et al., 2024; Trunk et al., 2020). Lindner et al. (2025) argue that AI has the potential to reduce the effects of bounded rationality by expanding information processing capabilities, but they also highlight risks such as algorithmic bias and flawed training data, reinforcing the need for human oversight.

Despite this progress, there remains a clear research gap regarding how these dynamics vary across different countries and local contexts. While there is substantial literature on AI as a technological phenomenon and on organizational decision-making, fewer studies have compared regional patterns in the adoption of AI within decision-making processes. In today's increasingly globalized world, where organizations frequently operate across national borders, understanding these variations is crucial.

If attitudes toward AI and its impact on decisions differ between contexts, this would suggest that a single, centralized approach to implementing impactful and efficient AI guidelines may not be effective. Current research in this area is still limited and often relies on large-scale quantitative analyses rather than in-depth qualitative studies that can uncover the underlying reasons behind these differences (e.g. Song et al., 2019). This thesis seeks to address this gap by exploring how factors related to intuitive decision-making, bounded rationality and technology acceptance shape the use and perception of AI in organizational decision-making, and by comparing regional patterns in these practices, contributing new insights and perspectives to the existing research.

1.3 Purpose and research question

The purpose of this study is to explore and describe the experiences, perceptions and adjustments made by managers across different geographical regions regarding the integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) into their daily decision-making processes.

Based on this purpose, the central research question is:
"What similarities and differences exist in attitudes toward AI and its influence on daily decision-making among managers in different regions of the same global tech company?"

2. Theoretical framework

2.1 Selection of theory

To identify relevant theories and research for this study, a literature search was conducted using digital databases accessed primarily through Uppsala University, including ScienceDirect, JSTOR and Business Source Complete (EBSCO). In addition, Google Scholar was used as an external search engine. Sources relevant to organizational decision-making and technology (AI) acceptance were prioritized. Moreover, the search focused on peer-reviewed articles in reputable journals (e.g. *Business Horizons*, *Management Science*, *Business Research* and *Journal of World Business*), books and frequently cited publications to ensure academic credibility. Keywords such as "artificial intelligence", "decision-making", "bounded rationality", "intuition", "human-AI interaction", "technology acceptance" and "international business" were combined in various ways to capture literature at the intersection of decision-making and AI adoption in a global organizational context.

2.2 Definition of AI

To ensure clarity in this thesis, a precise definition of AI must be established so that the research question can be adequately answered. Although there is no universally accepted definition of AI, there are widely recognized characteristics of what is considered Artificial Intelligence (Grobelnik et al., 2024). Moreover, attempts at more standardized definitions are emerging. For the purpose of this thesis, the OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) latest, revised definition of AI will be used as the foundational reference. The OECD (2024) defines AI as follows:

> "An AI system is a machine-based system that, for explicit or implicit objectives, infers, from the input it receives, how to generate outputs such as predictions, content, recommendations, or decisions that can influence physical or virtual environments. Different AI systems vary in their levels of autonomy and adaptiveness after deployment." (OECD, 2024, p. 4).

In the OECD definition, emphasis is placed on machine-based systems that take input data to generate outputs such as predictions, content, recommendations or decisions (OECD, 2024). This definition covers a broad spectrum of AI, from traditional systems to more adaptive, self-learning models that have emerged in recent years. Hence, it provides a solid baseline for defining what constitutes AI.

However, this thesis focuses specifically on Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI). Generative AI models (such as ChatGPT) operate by learning complex structures and relationships in vast datasets and then producing content that mimics human-like creativity (OECD, 2024).

2.3 Decision-making

Decision-making, a central theme in organizational theory and management studies, refers to the cognitive process of selecting a course of action among multiple alternatives. Foundational theories such as bounded rationality (Simon, 1955; 1979) and dual-system thinking (Kahneman, 2011) explain individual cognitive processes that influence organizational decisions. Understanding these processes is essential for this study, as they provide a basis for analyzing how managers interact with AI tools and integrate them into organizational decisions.

2.3.1 Bounded rationality

The concept of bounded rationality, introduced in the 1950s by Herbert A. Simon (1955; 1979), challenges the idea that decision-makers are capable of making perfectly rational decisions in any given situation. The notion of perfect rationality assumes that individuals have access to complete information, can objectively evaluate all alternatives and will always choose the optimal solution. In contrast to this theory of "omniscient rationality" (Simon, 1979, p. 496), Simon (1955; 1979) argued that decision-makers operate under internal and external constraints in complex real-world environments, where time, information and computational capacity are limited. Since they are unable to process all available information or anticipate every possible outcome, decision-makers instead rely on heuristics – mental shortcuts – and simplified models to make decisions within their cognitive boundaries. As a result, they often settle for a solution that is good enough or "satisficing" (Simon, 1979, p. 502). While not necessarily optimal, it adequately addresses the problem and is satisfactory enough to suffice.

In the context of organizational decision-making and AI, bounded rationality remains highly relevant. AI has the potential to alleviate some cognitive constraints by providing advanced data analysis and expanding information processing capabilities (Lindner et al., 2025;

Kubatko et al., 2024). However, its limitations, such as algorithmic bias and lack of contextual understanding, imply that human oversight is still essential (Leyer & Schneider, 2021; Menzies et al., 2024; Prasanth et al., 2023). Kourkoumelis et al. (2024) emphasize the need for extensive training in AI and, in line with Jarrahi (2018) and Trunk et al. (2020), argue that AI – given its lack of empathy – should augment rather than replace human judgment and leadership. This view is echoed by Vincent (2021), who highlights the interplay between computational power and human judgment. While AI systems can process vast amounts of data and offer analytical insights, human decision-makers still play a crucial role in interpreting these outputs, applying judgment and navigating ambiguity (Jarrahi, 2018; Vincent, 2021).

2.3.2 Intuitive decision-making

Perfect rationality underpins the rational decision-making model, which suggests that individuals use facts and information, analysis and a step-by-step procedure to reach a decision (Uzonwanne, 2016). This approach reflects deliberate, logical and analytical decision-making. In contrast, intuitive decision-making refers to the process of making judgments without explicit reasoning, often based on experience, pattern recognition and emotion. According to Dane et al. (2012), intuitive decision-making arises through rapid, nonconscious and holistic associations. Intuition is also affectively charged, a quality captured by the term “gut feeling” (Dane et al., 2012, p. 188).

Kahneman (2011) further explains the dichotomy between intuitive and analytical decision-making in his dual-system theory. He distinguishes between two modes of thinking: System 1 and System 2. System 1, which is fast, instinctive and emotional, operates automatically with little or no effort. It enables swift, intuitive decisions by relying on heuristics, which simplify complex judgments. Kahneman (2011) emphasizes that although System 1 is efficient and often sufficient for everyday decisions, its reliance on heuristics can lead to oversimplification, systematic errors and cognitive biases due to its tendency to overlook detailed information. Successful intuitive decisions in the past may also create a false sense of intuition’s infallibility, resulting in overconfidence in intuitive decision-making abilities (Kahneman, 2011; Sadler-Smith & Shefy, 2004). This tendency aligns with Leyer & Schneider’s (2021) findings that managers’ confidence in their own judgment is a major barrier to AI adoption, in addition to trust issues and a desire to maintain control.

As opposed to System 1, System 2 is slow, deliberate and logical. It requires focused attention and conscious effort, making it more suitable for tasks that involve analysis, reasoning and problem-solving. While System 2 can correct or override the impulsive judgments of System 1, it is more mentally demanding and often deferred unless necessary. As a result, the fast and automatic System 1 tends to dominate, even in complex and unfamiliar situations. This makes it the default mode of thinking, especially under time pressure, distraction or when mental effort is being preserved (Kahneman, 2011).

While intuition can be fallible, it remains a powerful tool when used by experienced professionals with domain-specific expertise (Dane et al., 2012). As Vincent (2021) observes, intuitive and analytical decision-making have often been contrasted to determine which is more effective, but some argue that this binary view is overly simplistic. Jarrahi (2018), for example, proposes that organizational decision-making can be enhanced by blending the two modes of thinking. Intuition can complement analytical approaches, particularly in uncertain or ambiguous contexts, when data is scarce or when decisions involve complex human factors. The interaction between intuition and analysis allows for flexible decision strategies, balancing speed and efficiency with accuracy and reflection. This is especially relevant in today's organizational settings, where both speed and depth are often required. It is also increasingly important in the context of AI, which introduces new possibilities for analytical support.

Vincent (2021) builds on this integrative view by proposing a model in which expert intuition and AI collaborate to improve decision quality. AI contributes data-driven insights and computational power, while human expert intuition adds contextual understanding and judgment. Rather than replacing human decision-making, AI is thus positioned as a complement to it, particularly when dealing with ill-structured tasks in ambiguous and complex environments, including organizational settings (Vincent, 2021). In such cases, an analytical approach alone may fall short, whereas expert intuition, validated by AI, can yield more effective results. This perspective aligns with the purpose of this study; to explore how managers engage with AI tools and balance analytical insights with intuitive judgment in organizational decision-making.

2.4 The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

The decision-making theories discussed provide insight into how managers process information and make judgments. To further understand how they adopt and interact with AI, the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) offers a complementary perspective focused on technology acceptance behavior.

2.4.1 Background on the Technology Acceptance Model

The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), developed by Fred Davis (1989), is a widely used framework for explaining how individuals accept and use new technologies. TAM is grounded in the Theory of Reasoned Action (TRA), which posits that human behavior is driven by behavioral intention, shaped by attitudes toward the behavior and social norms (Davis et al., 1989). TRA assumes that individuals act rationally, forming intentions based on evaluations of information and expected outcomes. Building on TRA, Davis (1989) adapted the model to a technological context by introducing two technology-specific determinants: Perceived Usefulness (PU) and Perceived Ease of Use (PEOU). TAM can thus be understood as an extension of TRA focused on technology adoption.

User acceptance is critical for successful IT implementation, as even technically sound systems may fail if not used (Davis, 1989). PU refers to the degree to which a person believes a system will enhance job performance, while PEOU refers to the degree to which the system is perceived as effortless to use (Davis, 1989). Together, these constructs form the core of TAM and explain why users adopt or reject new technologies.

2.4.2 TAM2 – an extension of Technology Acceptance Model

Although the original Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) successfully could explain user acceptance and use through PU and PEOU, there were also limitations to the model. Criticism of the model was primarily related to it being too narrow in scope, especially since it did not account for social and cognitive processes which influence the perceptions of PU and PEOU. To address these limitations, Venkatesh and Davis (2000) introduced an extension of the model: TAM2. This model expands the original model by incorporating two additional groups of factors; social influence processes and cognitive instrumental processes. The social influence factors – subjective norm, image and voluntariness – reflect the extent to which users' perceptions and intentions are shaped by the opinions of others and the organizational

environment. In parallel, the cognitive instrumental factors – job relevance, output quality and result demonstrability – explain how users form judgments about the system's usefulness based on their own tasks, performance outcomes and ability to observe tangible benefits (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000).

In TAM2, these social influence factors and cognitive instrumental processes shape PU, which together with PEOU determines intention to use the system, ultimately leading to usage behavior (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000, p.188). This model also recognizes that social norm may have a stronger influence in mandatory use contexts (voluntariness), but then tends to decline as users gain experience and evaluate the efficacy of the system. In addition, subjective norm can shape image, because when influential people such as managers or peers think AI should be used, it signals that AI usage is valued and respected. This expectation creates a perception that using AI improves professional image. Furthermore, voluntariness moderates the effect of subjective norm. When AI use is mandatory, subjective norm (i.e. social pressure) has a greater direct impact on intention because compliance is required. Conversely, when AI use is voluntary, subjective norm has little or no effect, and intention is driven mainly by PU and PEOU (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000). By integrating social and cognitive factors, this model (Figure 1) is a more comprehensive understanding of user acceptance in organizational settings. In these settings, user adoption tends to not only rely on the perceived efficiency but also on social and contextual dynamics in the organization (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000).

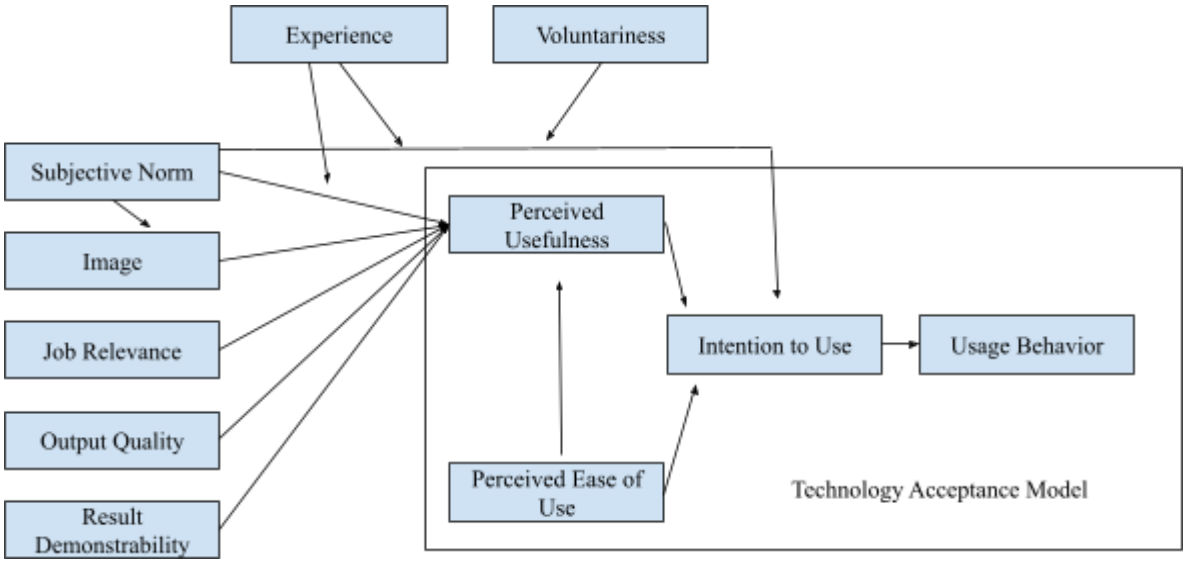


Figure 1: TAM2. Source: Venkatesh & Davis (2000)

2.5 Combined theoretical model

While TAM2 provides a strong foundation for understanding technology adoption through factors such as PU, PEOU, and social influence, it largely assumes rational decision-making. In practice, managerial decisions often occur under bounded rationality and are shaped by intuition, limited information, and time constraints. To capture this complexity, we propose a combined model (Figure 2) that integrates TAM2 with theories of bounded rationality and intuitive judgment. This model recognizes that managers may rely on heuristics and gut feeling, sometimes overriding AI recommendations despite positive perceptions of usefulness and ease of use, while increased trust in high-quality AI outputs may reduce reliance on intuition over time.

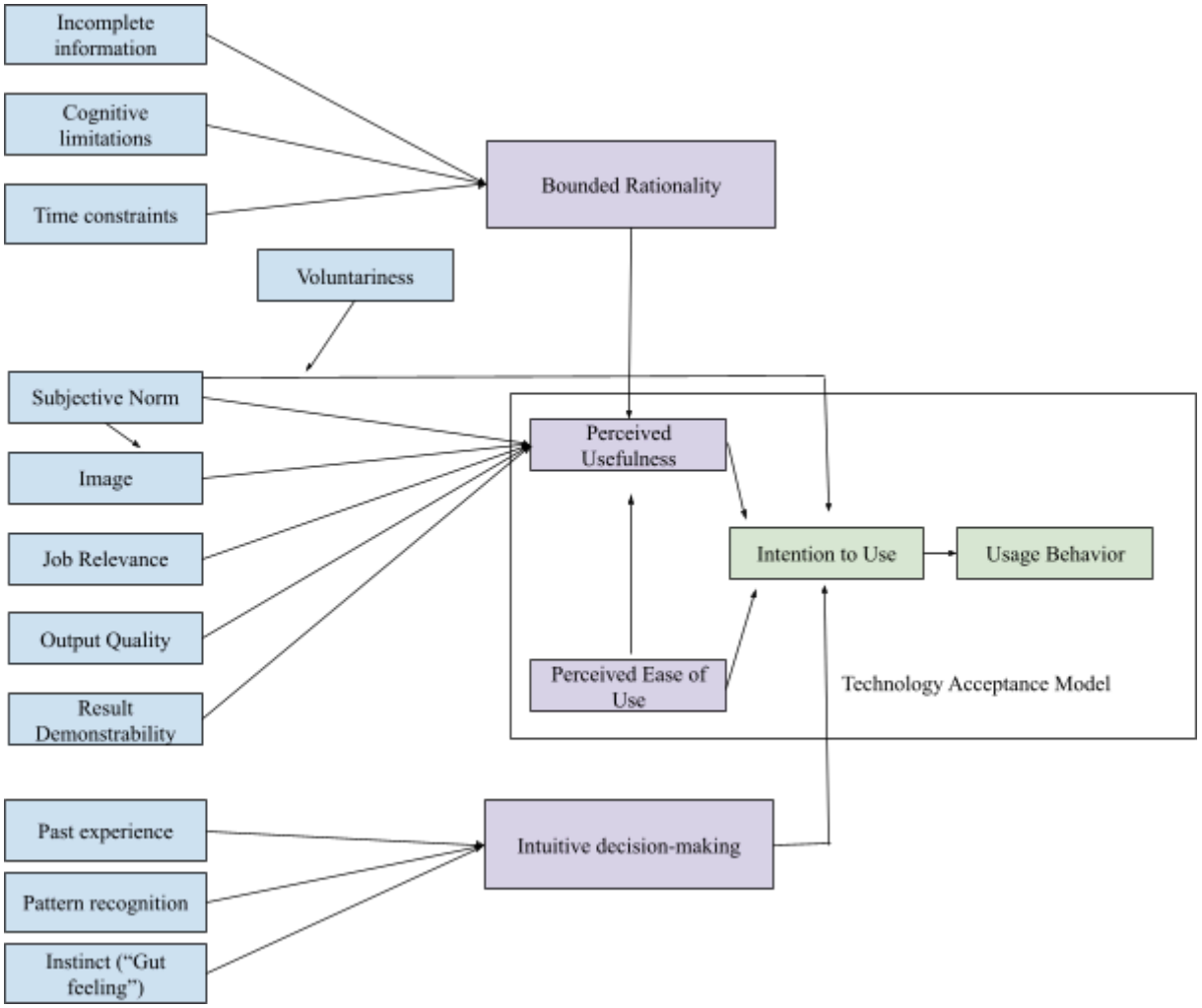


Figure 2: Combined model. Source: own illustration

The arrows in the model reflect how the different factors are expected to influence managers' use of AI. The core relationships come from TAM, where PU and PEOU shape intention to

use, which then affects usage behavior. The added TAM2 factors – subjective norm, image, job relevance, output quality and result demonstrability – all point toward PU because these elements help explain why managers in different contexts may find AI more or less valuable in their daily work. In TAM2, subjective norm is moderated not only by voluntariness but also by experience. This is based on the assumption that its influence diminishes as users gain familiarity with the technology. However, this study adopts a cross-sectional design and does not examine changes in experience over time, making this moderating factor less relevant. Moreover, since the respondents are managers with established decision-making responsibilities and daily exposure to AI tools, variation in experience is unlikely to meaningfully affect perceptions of usefulness or intention to use. Therefore, experience was removed from the model to simplify it and focus on factors most relevant to decision-making in this context.

Bounded rationality is connected to PU because time pressure, limited information and cognitive constraints can make AI appear more attractive as a support tool. In other words, the more constrained a manager feels, the more useful AI may seem. This perspective aligns with Lindner et al. (2025), who argue that AI can mitigate the effects of bounded rationality by processing large amounts of data and reducing decision complexity. Under such conditions, managers are likely to perceive AI as more useful in their decision-making.

On the intuitive side, past experience, pattern recognition and instinct (‘gut feeling’) feed into intuitive decision-making, which then links to intention to use. This arrow reflects that managers’ intuition can either support or challenge AI recommendations, influencing whether they choose to rely on AI or not. This relationship is supported by Vincent (2021), who notes that intuition often guides decisions under uncertainty, and Jarrahi (2018), who emphasizes that human-AI collaboration depends on trust and complementarity. Building on these ideas, when intuition aligns with AI, managers may be more inclined to use it; when it conflicts, they may hesitate.

Overall, the arrows indicate how both rational evaluations and intuitive judgments shape managers’ attitudes toward AI and their tendency to use it in everyday decision-making. This combined approach provides a more holistic understanding of AI adoption in organizational settings, where technological acceptance and human judgment co-exist and

interact.

2.6 Summary of theoretical framework

In this thesis, the term Artificial Intelligence (AI) refers specifically to Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI). The study draws on two theoretical perspectives to explore managerial attitudes toward AI in decision-making: intuitive decision-making theories and the extended Technology Acceptance Model (TAM2). Bounded rationality and intuitive decision-making, including concepts such as dual-system theory, acknowledge that managers often make decisions with limited information, under time pressure, and guided by heuristics or 'gut feeling'. In contrast, TAM2 provides a rational model that explains technology adoption based on PU and PEOU, while also taking social and cognitive factors into account. For the purpose of this study, these theories are treated as complementary.

To capture the complexity of how managers engage with AI, both frameworks are operationalized in the design of interview questions and data analysis. This approach allows for a nuanced understanding of whether attitudes toward AI are shaped more by rational evaluation or intuitive judgment, and how these tendencies may vary across regional and cultural contexts. It also reflects the reality that decision-making in organizational settings often involves a mix of analytical reasoning and experiential intuition, especially when interacting with emerging technologies like AI.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research design

This thesis adopts a comparative qualitative research design to explore attitudes and experiences related to AI in decision-making across different regions (see Table 1). A qualitative approach is particularly suitable, as the aim is not statistical generalizability but rather a deep, contextual understanding (Denscombe, 2018) of the processes and perceptions surrounding the use of AI in geographically diverse settings. This design enables a collection of rich, detailed insights into complex phenomena such as AI adoption, which are difficult to capture through quantitative methods (Denscombe, 2018). The exploratory nature of the research further supports the use of a flexible and interpretive approach that can capture emerging themes and diverse viewpoints. To complement these qualitative insights, supportive Likert-scale statements were included to provide a general indication of attitudes toward AI. A scale of 1–5 was used, where 1 = Strongly disagree and 5 = Strongly agree. For simplicity, these are referred to as 'the statements' throughout the remainder of the thesis.

AI tools were used in this thesis for suggestions on structure, phrasing and focus points. The suggestions were critically reviewed and revised, and all core content, analysis and interpretations were developed by the authors.

3.2 Data collection

The study focuses on nine managers within a single global tech company. The managers work in the same function (Operations), but are based in different countries. The sample covers three geographically distinct company regions (with three managers per region) to ensure diversity and variation in local organizational contexts. A prerequisite for interviewing the company's employees was that all personal and company identifiers be kept anonymous.

Data was collected through digital interviews combining the statements with open-ended questions. Semi-structured interviews like these allow for a nuanced exploration of experiences and perspectives, offering a more holistic understanding of the topic (Denscombe, 2018). The statements were included to give a general sense of attitudes and serve as a reference point for interpreting the qualitative responses, rather than for detailed statistical analysis. The interview questions were structured around key areas such as AI integration and reliance, examining how AI is used and the degree of its acceptance, and perceptions of AI,

including the motivations, rationalizations and processes that underlie managers' attitudes toward AI.

The interviews followed a structured questionnaire (Appendix A). While the first part (the statements) was standardized, the second part (open-ended questions) allowed for greater flexibility. In some cases, follow-up questions were posed to clarify or elaborate on respondents' answers. At the beginning of each interview, the respondents were informed about the purpose of the study and their rights in accordance with the ethical principles outlined in chapter 3.5. Key concepts, including 'generative AI' and 'decision-making', were defined to ensure clarity. Based on the respondents' informed consent, the interviews were recorded. They were subsequently transcribed, reviewed and coded, as described in chapter 3.3.

To test the clarity and effectiveness of the questionnaire, a pilot interview was conducted prior to the main data collection. The purpose of this pilot was to ensure that the wording was unambiguous and comprehensible, and that the statements elicited sufficiently distinct reactions rather than a neutral position (e.g. '3' on a Likert scale of 1–5). Based on the feedback, several statements were rephrased to make them more precise and thought-provoking. For variation, some statements were also reversed so that a score of '1' indicated strong agreement with the underlying construct.

3.2.1 Selection of respondents

The selection of respondents was shaped by the purpose of the study, which is to explore how managers in different countries perceive and experience the use of AI in their daily decision-making. To ensure analytical comparability while still capturing meaningful contextual variation, the study focused on managers within Operations of the same global tech company. The choice of a global technology company was intentional, as such organizations are typically at the forefront of AI adoption, making it reasonable to assume that AI tools are already embedded in everyday managerial practices. This particular company was also chosen due to organizational access and feasibility. The company's presence across multiple markets and regions enabled the examination of AI use in diverse national contexts while holding organizational structures, technologies and overarching policies constant.

The respondents were selected partly due to accessibility, but also because their roles involve

frequent operational decision-making where AI tools and company-wide guidelines may come into play. Although the participants are managers within the same function, they work in nine different countries, each characterized by distinct market conditions, regulatory environments and operational demands. Since the company has implemented centralized AI guidelines and made AI use mandatory for its employees, interviewing managers across several countries allowed for an exploration of how standardized AI principles are interpreted, adapted and applied within diverse local contexts.

To bring structure to the sampling process, the available countries were grouped into three broader regions, following the company's own internal regional division. From each region, three managers were selected based on accessibility and willingness to participate. This approach ensured a geographically diverse sample while remaining feasible within the scope and time constraints of the thesis.

In total, nine semi-structured interviews were conducted (Table 1). While selecting participants from a single company and function introduces some degree of homogeneity, the geographical spread of respondents provides important variation in how AI is perceived and used in daily decision-making. These considerations, along with the limitations of the sampling approach, are addressed in chapter 3.4.

Table 1: Selected respondents, date and duration of the interview

Respondent	Country	Region	Date	Duration
1 (R1)	Denmark	1 (North)	Dec 5	43:32
2 (R2)	Latvia	1 (North)	Dec 5	49:15
3 (R3)	Finland	1 (North)	Dec 11	33:45
4 (R4)	Hungary	2 (Central)	Dec 9	43:08
5 (R5)	Serbia	2 (Central)	Dec 10	46:13
6 (R6)	Slovakia	2 (Central)	Dec 12	38:51
7 (R7)	Israel	3 (East)	Dec 14	33:12
8 (R8)	Azerbaijan	3 (East)	Dec 9	43:07
9 (R9)	Kazakhstan	3 (East)	Dec 11	33:39

3.2.2 Operationalization

To ensure alignment between theory and data collection, key constructs from the theoretical framework were operationalized into 44 statements and eight open-ended interview questions (Appendix A). Although Venkatesh and Davis' (2000) TAM2 uses quantitative scale items, the underlying approach, breaking down each factor into concrete aspects, guides the operationalization process. This involved identifying how factors such as PU, subjective norm, job relevance, intuitive judgment and bounded rationality might appear in managers' practical decision-making. These elements were then reformulated into measurement statements suitable for Likert assessment, as well as deeper exploratory questions aimed at capturing attitudes, experiences and contextual interpretations. This dual approach ensured that each theoretical construct was examined from both a measurable and a more nuanced, descriptive perspective.

Some TAM2 constructs (e.g. subjective norm, intention to use) represent straightforward concepts and can be reliably measured with one or two items, whereas others (e.g. PU, usage behavior) are multidimensional and require multiple items to reflect their full scope. For the statements, a Likert scale of 1–5 was selected. Since this study is exploratory and qualitative, the scale is meant to capture general attitudes rather than support detailed statistical analysis. A 5-point scale is straightforward and easy for respondents to use, while still providing enough variation to identify patterns. Given the small sample size and the fact that these statements are only intended to complement the qualitative insights, a more detailed 7-point scale would add unnecessary complexity.

3.3 Data analysis

Due to the small sample size (three respondents per region), the 44 statements were analyzed descriptively. For reversed items, where a score of '1' indicated strong agreement with the underlying construct, scores were re-coded (e.g. 1 → 5, 2 → 4) so that higher values consistently reflected stronger agreement. This step ensured comparability across all statements. To facilitate interpretation, scores were collapsed into three categories: Disagree (1–2), Neutral (3) and Agree (4–5). Respondents often explained that selecting '3' meant they neither agreed nor disagreed, or that they both agreed and disagreed depending on the situation. This was interpreted as not expressing a clear stance and the midpoint (3) was thus treated as neutral. Although collapsing categories simplifies presentation and highlights

overall tendencies, it also reduces the richness and detail of the data while potentially obscuring subtle differences in response strength. Given the limited sample size, this trade-off was considered acceptable to enable clearer comparisons across regions.

Items were grouped into clusters representing the underlying constructs (e.g. TAM2 factors such as PU, PEOU and subjective norm, as well as bounded rationality and intuitive decision-making). For each cluster and region, frequencies per category (Disagree/Neutral/Agree) were summarized by counting the number of scores falling into each of the categories. To enable a straightforward comparison across clusters and regions, the proportion of scores in the top two categories (Agree = 4–5) was calculated as an indicator of positive orientation toward the construct (e.g. for PU with four items, eight out of twelve responses in Region 1 were a '4' or a '5', i.e. 8/12 = 67%). Moreover, to provide a simple reference point for interpreting response patterns, the mode was included as an additional descriptive indicator of the most frequent score within each cluster and region. Statement responses from each respondent are presented in Appendix B, while cluster-level summaries are reported in the Results to enable comparison across regions and integration with qualitative themes.

The collected data from the open-ended interview questions was analysed using thematic analysis, a flexible and widely used method in qualitative research for identifying, analyzing and reporting patterns within data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). This approach is particularly suitable for examining complex phenomena – in this case attitudes toward AI and its influence on decision-making – as it allows for both inductive and deductive interpretation and supports rich, detailed insights.

The analysis followed Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step process:

1. **Familiarization with data**: Interview transcripts were read multiple times to gain a deep understanding of the content. Initial thoughts and observations were noted during this stage.
2. **Generating initial codes**: The data was systematically coded to identify meaningful features and recurring patterns.

3. **Searching for themes**: Codes were then organized into potential overarching themes, guided primarily by the study's theoretical framework. A thematic map was created to visualize relationships.
4. **Reviewing potential themes**: Themes were refined to ensure they accurately represented the data. This involved checking coherence within and across themes.
5. **Defining and naming themes**: Each theme was clearly defined and named to reflect its core meaning and relevance to the research questions.
6. **Writing the report**: The final step involved presenting the thematic findings through a coherent narrative, linking them to the research questions and theoretical framework, and illustrating them with representative data excerpts.

This structured yet flexible approach enabled the identification of themes that were both grounded in the data and the theoretical framework. The mapping of codes to their corresponding themes (thematic map) is included in Appendix D for transparency. A cross-regional comparison was also conducted to identify key similarities and differences in themes, providing insight into how context influences decision-making processes.

3.4 Limitations and quality of research

While this study provides insights into managerial attitudes toward AI, several limitations should be acknowledged. First, the sample size is relatively small (nine respondents) and drawn from a single global tech company. This raises the possibility of selection bias. As Denscombe (2018) notes, qualitative research often relies on convenience or subjective (purposive) sampling, which can introduce bias as participants may not represent the wider population. This, in turn, may limit the external validity or generalizability of the findings (Denscombe, 2018). In this study, respondents were largely selected based on accessibility and willingness to participate, which may influence the diversity of perspectives. Although the respondents' geographical diversity introduces contextual variation, the results do not necessarily represent other industries or organizational structures. The aim of this study, however, is not statistical representativeness but rather exploratory insight.

Second, social desirability and selective recall may have influenced the data. As Denscombe (2018) points out, interview participants sometimes claim to think or act in ways that do not necessarily reflect their actual behavior or true opinions. This tendency can lead to social desirability bias, where responses are shaped by what is perceived as acceptable or favorable

rather than what is genuine. Similarly, selective recall can occur when respondents remember certain experiences while omitting others. This may result in incomplete or skewed accounts (Denscombe, 2018). Self-reported data through interviews and statements inherently introduces these risks. To mitigate them, the interview questions were designed to be as open and non-leading as possible, with the aim of encouraging candid responses. This included phrasing questions broadly, avoiding assumptions about the respondent's practices and inviting them to describe their experiences in their own words.

Third, the interviews were conducted in English, and while this is the company's working language, it is not the nine respondents' native tongue. As Denscombe (2018) emphasizes, clarity of communication is essential for validity in qualitative research. Using a non-native language may have limited the depth of responses or introduced misunderstandings. To address this, clear, simple language was used and respondents were encouraged to ask for clarification when needed.

3.5 Ethical considerations

The study followed the ethical principles outlined by Vetenskapsrådet (2024, pp. 57–70), particularly those concerning respect for human dignity, informed consent, confidentiality and responsible data handling. All participants were informed about the purpose of the study, what their participation involved and how their data would be handled. This was communicated both when they were invited and at the start of each interview. Informed consent was obtained before participation, including permission to record the interview and use direct quotations. The participants were also told that they could skip any question they did not want to answer and withdraw from the study at any time. To ensure transparency, quotations were sent to the participants for approval before being included in the thesis. All identifying details were anonymized and recordings and transcripts were stored securely with restricted access. The material will only be used for this thesis and deleted after its completion.

These measures reflect Vetenskapsrådet's (2024) emphasis on protecting participants' integrity, ensuring voluntary participation and balancing openness with confidentiality.

4. Results

The results from the nine interviews are presented in three different tables, which summarize the data collected through the statements and open-ended questions. Table 3 shows a compilation of the responses to the 44 statements. The clusters represent the theoretical constructs from Figure 2: Combined model (e.g., bounded rationality, intuitive decision-making and TAM2 factors such as PU and PEOU). For each cluster, the table displays the number of items, the total number of responses per region (R), the distribution of responses across the three categories (Disagree = 1–2, Neutral = 3, Agree = 4–5) for each region, the proportion of responses in the top two categories (Agree = 4–5) – calculated with the formula Agr/R – and mode. This provides an overview of how respondents rated different aspects of AI in decision-making across regions. Table 2 explains the terms used in Table 3.

Table 2: Explanation of Table 3

Cluster	The summarized concept/construct represented by the items.
Number of items	Total number of items (questions) per category.
Responses per region (R)	Number of items multiplied with responses per region (3).
Dis*	Out of (R), how many responses were 1–2 (disagree).
Neu*	Out of (R), how many responses were 3 (neutral).
Agr*	Out of (R), how many responses were 4–5 (agree).
% of responses rated 4–5 (Agr/R)	Out of (R), how many responses were 4–5 (%).
Mode (1–5)	The number of times each score occurred was counted, and the score with the highest occurrence within each cluster and region was identified as the mode.
*** Under each region**	

Table 4 presents the overall thematic analysis results. The main themes were identified from the coding of the transcribed interviews (see Appendices C and D) following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step process. The table lists each theme, a brief description, the number of respondents who expressed it and illustrative quotes. This table captures recurring patterns in how the participating managers perceive and use AI in their daily decision-making processes.

Table 5 compares the identified themes across regions. For each theme, the table shows how many respondents in each region mentioned it. This regional breakdown highlights the distribution of themes across the three geographical contexts included in the study.

Table 3: Statement responses

Cluster	Number of items	Responses per region (R)	Region 1 (North)			Region 2 (Central)			Region 3 (East)			% of responses rated 4–5 (Agr/R)			Mode (1–5)		
			Dis	*Neu*	*Agr*	*Dis*	*Neu*	*Agr*	*Dis*	*Neu*	*Agr*	*R1*	*R2*	*R3*	*R1*	*R2*	*R3*
Bounded Rationality	9	27	9	7	11	5	6	16	9	7	11	41	59	41	4	4	4
Intuitive Decision-Making	9	27	1	5	21	3	8	16	2	5	20	78	59	74	4	4	5
Usage Behavior	5	15	4	6	5	2	1	12	9	2	4	33	80	27	3	4	2
Intention to use	1	3	0	0	3	0	0	3	0	2	1	100	100	33	5	5	3
Perceived ease of use (PEOU)	3	9	2	3	4	1	6	2	3	3	3	44	22	33	3	3	3/4
Perceived usefulness (PU)	4	12	0	4	8	0	1	11	7	4	2	67	92	17	4	4	2
Subjective norm	1	3	1	0	2	1	1	1	1	1	1	67	33	33	1/4/5	2/3/4	2/3/5
Voluntariness	2	6	6	0	0	6	0	0	6	0	0	0	0	0	1	2	1/2
Image	2	6	3	0	3	2	0	4	0	3	3	50	67	50	2/4	4	3
Job relevance	2	6	0	0	6	0	2	4	2	1	3	100	67	50	4	5	4
Output quality	3	9	0	5	4	1	4	4	3	5	1	44	44	11	3	3/4	3
Result demonstrability	3	9	0	1	8	0	2	7	3	2	4	89	78	44	4	4	4

Table 4: Overall thematic analysis

Theme	Description	(n)	Regions	Illustrative quotes
AI as a cognitive shortcut under time and information pressure	AI is used for time-saving and efficiency, i.e. to rapidly gather information, summarize data and reduce cognitive load when time, clarity or information is limited.	7	3	R2: "AI just puts it on my table summarized beautifully." R3: "Without me doing the heavy lifting in terms of adding or computing things." R5: "Time… is the biggest gain." R6: "AI… is giving me more time, so in a quicker way I can just find what I'm searching for." R9: "When you're overwhelmed with tasks… you kind of don't have another choice"
AI as an analytical tool for structuring, calculating and understanding data	Perceived usefulness for data analysis, KPIs, scenarios and making sense of complex or unfamiliar datasets.	8	3	R1: "I make my AI to analyze some data for me and give me some trends." R3: "I use AI to give me possible scenarios… to take a risk that is more calculated." R4: "When the decision-making process includes data analysis, then without a doubt that is super useful." R5: "Data analysis absolutely." R7: "Mainly when it comes to analyze metrics and data." R9: "99% of the time it's numbers-related"
AI as a 'second opinion'/ sparring partner/decision challenger	AI helps managers reflect, challenge assumptions and explore alternative perspectives without taking over the final decision.	6	2	R1 :"I've basically set it up as my sparring partner." R2: "If I… need a second opinion… I would reach out to AI for advice." R3: "AI would allow me to really question my own choices." R4: "I ask if… there might be any other things which I haven't considered yet." R6: "It's always good to have second opinion."
Trust is conditional and fragile; verification is required (no blind trust)	Managers trust AI only when outputs are consistent, source-backed or aligned with experience; verification is routine; errors or fabricated info quickly erode trust.	6	3	R1: "No matter the question… I always review it and don't blindly trust it." R4: "If it doesn't [have links], I ask it to back it up with some official websites." R6: "I always check the calculation by my own calculation." R8: "I asked for the sources… It lies a lot." R9: "I see how many mistakes it makes… I try to double-check the data."
AI's usefulness/reliability depends on the nature of the task (data vs. people)	AI is viewed as highly useful for data-driven and analytical tasks, but not appropriate for people-related, ethical or emotionally complex decisions.	9	3	R2: "I would mostly trust the hard data." R3: "The nuances of human behavior, AI doesn't have it." R5: "I did it for salaries, but soft HR – no." R7: "When it comes to HR subjects – no, hard data – yes." R8: "Totally against it… people-related decisions are not for the AI for now."
Organisational and technical constraints shape actual adoption	Confidentiality requirements, tool limitations, lack of integration with internal systems and uneven technical performance constrain how managers can use AI in practice.	5	3	R2: "There's a lot of company confidential information that I should not share." R5: "I have struggled with automatization of the process… it could help a lot." R8: "I would love to see AI integration to our tools… our mails, Slack." R9: "There are often some bugs… it cannot read a doc or open a CSV file or something breaks."

Theme	Description	(n)	Regions	Illustrative quotes
Using AI requires skill: prompting, interpretation and digital competence	Effective use of AI depends on the manager's ability to prompt, interpret responses, refine queries and navigate the tool. This cognitive effort has a learning curve and affects adoption.	9	3	R2: "You really need to define what you're looking for correctly." R3: "I'm learning more and more to have the correct prompts." R6: "You should put all the information… in a neutral way." R7: "You always need to go again and again… it can take hours or even days to get to the outcome." R8: "It's very difficult to explain what you want… I started courses on prompt engineering." R9: "I've been trying to learn how to give better prompts."
The final decision remains human: intuition and experience dominate	Managers rely on their own experience, intuition and contextual knowledge. AI informs decisions but never replaces human judgement.	9	3	R1: "It's always me who defines the final [decision]." R2: "Decision would be mine at the end." R6: "I never make the decision based on the output from AI." R7: "My own intuition will always override AI – 10 out of 10." R8: "I will decide from my judgment."

Table 5: Cross-regional comparison of themes

Theme	Region 1 (North)	Region 2 (Central)	Region 3 (East)
AI as a cognitive shortcut under time and information pressure	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 1
AI as an analytical tool for structuring, calculating and understanding data	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 2
AI as a 'second opinion'/sparring partner/decision challenger	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 0
Trust is conditional and fragile; verification is required (no blind trust)	Mentioned by 1	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 2
AI's usefulness depends on the nature of the task (data vs. people)	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3
Organisational and technical constraints shape actual adoption	Mentioned by 1	Mentioned by 2	Mentioned by 2
Using AI requires skill: prompting, interpretation and digital competence	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3
The final decision remains human: intuition and experience dominate	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3	Mentioned by 3

5. Analysis and discussion

5.1 Overview

The purpose of this study was to explore how nine managers across three regions engage with AI in their daily decision-making processes, and if any regional similarities and differences in attitudes toward AI exist. Overall, the findings indicate that AI is used as an augmentation tool that reduces cognitive load in data-centric, time-pressured or complex decisions, while final decisions remain human – especially for people-related or ethically sensitive issues. Moreover, adoption depends on demonstrable outputs and calibrated trust, not simply availability of tools. The responses to the statements reinforce this picture. PU is strongest where outputs are demonstrable (Region 2), while PEOU is low to modest across regions (Region 1: 44%; Region 2: 22%; Region 3: 33%). Intention to use and usage behavior generally follow PU more than PEOU, which is consistent with TAM2 (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000). The discussion draws on both respondents' responses to the statements and their answers to the open-ended questions.

5.2 Theme-by-theme analysis

5.2.1 AI as a cognitive shortcut under time and information pressure

A central finding across respondents from all regions is that managers primarily engage with AI as a cognitive shortcut when facing time pressure, incomplete information or high task complexity. As R3 explains: "I normally use AI when it's very short in time for extracting or making sense of a dataset… without me doing the heavy lifting in terms of adding or computing things." This perspective aligns with Lindner et al. (2025), who argue that the effects of bounded rationality can be mitigated by AI. Rather than attempting to fully optimize decisions, managers in this study use AI to reduce the cognitive burden associated with searching, summarizing and structuring information. In other words, they aim for a solution that, in Simon's (1979) terminology, is "satisficing" (p. 502) under constraints, and AI serves as a tool to achieve this more efficiently than through manual processing. This is consistent with Almutairi and Almatrodi (2025), who note that when decisions are made under bounded rationality, users tend to accept AI as a satisficing solution, especially when outputs align with their values and expectations.

The responses to the statements support this interpretation. Agreement with bounded rationality indicators is highest in Region 2 (59%), which also shows the strongest PU (92%) and highest usage behavior (80%). This suggests that AI is valued most in contexts where

cognitive constraints are particularly pronounced for the respondents. Under such conditions, they appear to be more willing to accept imperfections in ease of use or accuracy, as the alternative, being manual information processing, would be perceived as more costly. This finding extends Lindner et al.'s (2025) argument by showing that AI's value is not intrinsic, but emerges specifically under conditions of pressure, overload and uncertainty.

Importantly, this theme also explains why PU can outweigh PEOU (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000). When AI reliably reduces cognitive effort in constrained situations, respondents tolerate the additional effort associated with prompting, refining and verifying outputs. AI thus functions less as a general-purpose decision-maker and more as a situational coping mechanism for bounded rationality.

At the same time, the findings indicate that AI does not eliminate cognitive effort entirely, but rather redistributes it. While AI reduces the burden of information search and initial sensemaking, it introduces new cognitive demands related to prompting, interpreting outputs and verifying results. This suggests that AI functions as a selective relief mechanism for bounded rationality rather than a comprehensive solution, reducing some constraints while introducing others. As later themes show, whether this trade-off is perceived as feasible depends on the respondents' trust in outputs, task characteristics and additional factors.

5.2.2 AI as an analytical tool for structuring, calculating and understanding data

Across all regions, AI is consistently described as most useful for analytical, numerical and data-intensive tasks. Respondents rely on AI to structure datasets, run scenarios, identify trends and support quantitative reasoning, particularly in unfamiliar or complex contexts. For example, R4 states that "when the decision-making process includes data analysis, then without a doubt [AI] is super useful". These use cases map directly onto TAM2's cognitive instrumental processes – job relevance, output quality and result demonstrability – which are theorized to shape PU (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000).

Regional differences reveal that this usefulness can be fragile. Region 2 reports high output quality and demonstrability, corresponding with exceptionally high PU and frequent usage. In contrast, Region 3 reports very low output quality (11%) and limited demonstrability (44%) which coincides with low PU (17%) and weak adoption. This suggests that analytical usefulness depends not only on task type but also on whether AI outputs are perceived as reliable, consistent and verifiable.

From a cognitive perspective, unreliable analytical outputs increase rather than reduce cognitive load, as respondents must invest additional effort in checking, correcting and contextualizing results. R8 states that "most AIs… are lying", while R9 mentions "bugs" and claims to "see how many mistakes it makes". When respondents must "double-check" (R9) results, the potential benefits of using AI (e.g. time-saving and efficiency) diminish. Cognitive load can thus be reduced or increased depending on reliability and integration (Leyer & Schneider, 2021). This aligns with Leyer and Schneider's (2021) argument that poorly performing AI systems undermine decision augmentation by shifting work back to the human decision-maker. Thus, AI's analytical value is conditional: it supports decision-making only when it demonstrably simplifies rather than complicates analytical reasoning.

These findings suggest a threshold effect in analytical decision support: once perceived output quality and result demonstrability fall below an acceptable level, AI no longer functions as a cognitive aid but instead becomes a source of additional work. In such cases, respondents' trust in AI erodes, and the need for constant verification outweighs potential efficiency gains, as reflected in the low usage behavior observed in Region 3.

5.2.3 AI as 'second opinion'/sparring partner/decision challenger

Respondents in Regions 1 and 2 describe AI as a sparring partner that challenges assumptions, broadens perspectives and helps test preliminary judgments. For example, R1 explains that they have "basically set it up as my sparring partner", describing "a lot of back-and-forth sparring before I then in the end have come to… the way I need to go". Similarly, R3 notes that "AI would allow me to really question my own choices". R6 adds: "It's always good to have [a] second opinion." In these cases, AI does not provide final answers but instead functions as a cognitive mirror, prompting managers to reflect on their own reasoning. This use of AI alters *how* decisions are made without changing *who* ultimately decides.

The responses to the statements reinforce this pattern: all respondents agreed or strongly agreed that they feel more confident in their intuitive decisions when AI points in the same direction. AI is therefore most readily accepted when it confirms, rather than contradicts, existing judgments. This aligns with Almutairi and Almatrodi's (2025) finding that users' acceptance of AI increases when its outputs match their preferences or expectations, highlighting how agreement with intuition can strengthen trust and encourage adoption.

This interactional role illustrates a more nuanced form of decision augmentation. Rather than replacing human judgment, AI expands the decision space by surfacing alternatives and counterarguments. When AI aligns with intuition, respondents report increased confidence. When it conflicts, reactions vary. Managers in Region 2 are more inclined to question their own judgment when AI input conflicts with intuition, whereas managers in Regions 1 and 3 tend to privilege intuition and prioritize their own experience. None of the respondents in region 3 report using AI in this role, reflecting skepticism, low PU and concerns about reliability.

These differences suggest that regional context may influence how managers calibrate trust between their own judgment and AI-generated input, even within a single organizational framework. The findings support integrative models of decision-making, which argue that intuition and analytical tools are most effective when combined rather than opposed (Jarrahi, 2018; Vincent, 2021; Trunk et al., 2020). AI's value in this context lies not in providing correct answers, but in its capacity to stimulate reflection, challenge reasoning and reduce stagnation in decision-making processes.

5.2.4 Trust is conditional and fragile; verification is required (no blind trust)

Trust emerges as a necessary but fragile condition for AI use across all regions. For the majority of respondents, trust in AI is earned rather than assumed. As R1 notes: "I always review it and don't blindly trust it." Others emphasize the need for source validation and consistency: "If it doesn't have links, I ask it to back it up with official websites" (R4); "I asked for the sources… it lies a lot" (R8); "I'm always a bit skeptical because… I see how many mistakes it makes… I try to double-check the data" (R9). Verification practices such as triangulating sources, rephrasing prompts and manually checking calculations are therefore widespread and routine across all three regions. As Almutairi and Almatrodi (2025) note, trust depends strongly on perceived competence and users are more likely to rely on AI when systems demonstrate accuracy and reliability over time.

Region 3 illustrates how fragile trust undermines adoption. Low output quality and limited result demonstrability correspond with low PU and weak usage behavior, as the perceived potential of AI fails to translate into actual use when trust signals are weak. In these situations, respondents engage in extensive verification to compensate for uncertainty about

accuracy and reliability. While this may protect decision quality, it erodes the time-saving benefits that initially motivated AI use. As a result, AI becomes cognitively expensive rather than efficient.

Recent research suggests that trust and decision quality improve when AI provides transparency cues such as explanations and accuracy estimates – a principle central to Explainable AI, XAI (e.g. Eisbach et al., 2023; Chen et al. 2023; Senoner et al., 2024; Almutairi & Almatrodi, 2025). Eisbach et al. (2023) show that appropriate trust calibration, meaning the alignment of users' trust with the AI system's actual reliability – occurs when users receive explicit accuracy information (e.g. confidence levels or quality indicators) and are encouraged to elaborate on outputs. Over-reliance ('blind trust') or misinterpretation of accuracy cues, on the other hand, can degrade performance.

In the absence of formal accuracy or transparency signals, several respondents demonstrate that they manually calibrate trust. This includes asking AI the same question in different ways, triangulating outputs and verifying results independently (e.g. R6: "I'm asking… then I'm asking from a different way and checking what is the answer now… and then probably I start to be confident if the answer is still the same"). These practices reflect what Eisbach et al. (2023) describe as motivating elaboration; actively engaging with AI recommendations rather than relying on them passively. However, while such engagement may safeguard decision quality, it also increases time and mental effort, which in turn can undermine PU and sustained adoption. This implies that selective verification is key in this context: while scrutiny may be warranted when uncertainty, complexity or stakes are high, transparency cues and explanations can signal when extra checks may be safely omitted. By reducing unnecessary verification, these features could thus help preserve AI's net benefit under bounded rationality.

5.2.5 AI's usefulness/reliability depends on the nature of the task (data vs. people)

One of the most stable findings across all regions is the clear boundary managers draw between data-driven decisions and people-related or ethically sensitive decisions. AI is widely accepted as useful for analytical and numerical tasks, but consistently rejected as a decision-maker in matters involving human judgment, emotional complexity or significant consequences for individuals (e.g. R5: "I did it for salaries, but soft HR – no"; R7: "I would not take an HR decision according to AI"; R8: "Totally against it… people-related decisions are not for the AI for now"). While AI may support information gathering or reflection in

these situations, respondents emphasize that responsibility for people-related decisions must remain human.

Across interviews, respondents highlight AI's limited ability to capture contextual nuance, situational awareness and tacit knowledge that are central to managing people. Decisions involving performance, behavior or interpersonal dynamics are described as deeply embedded in local context and everyday interaction, which are difficult to formalize or fully communicate to an AI. As R2 affirms: "I wouldn't fully trust AI as I can't always explain in every small detail the severity of the situation… AI is not able to read through people's emotions." Similarly, R3 notes: "AI can say that [a person] is the best worker you have because she's very quick in what she does, but then I know that [a person] also shows up late quite often… sometimes it doesn't fully capture the worker's attitude at work." These examples illustrate how quantitative indicators alone are insufficient for evaluating or managing people-related performance.

In addition, respondents express discomfort with allowing AI to influence decisions that directly affect individuals in their teams. Even when AI is perceived as potentially accurate, accountability and judgment are seen as inherently human responsibilities. This resistance reflects a shared understanding of task suitability rather than a general opposition to AI. Respondents view AI as appropriate for structured, quantifiable tasks, but ill-suited for decisions requiring empathy, moral judgment and contextual interpretation.

This task-dependent boundary is consistent with prior research on trust in AI. For example, Yang and Wibowo (2022) show that user trust in AI is conditional and varies with task characteristics such as complexity and verifiability. Floridi (2025) further argues that a fundamental trade-off between certainty and scope lies at the core of AI-design: well-defined tasks typically induce high certainty, whereas broad, ambiguous tasks tend to result in lower certainty. This mirrors the findings of this study, where respondents express confidence in AI primarily within bounded, quantifiable domains, while withholding trust in people-related decisions that are difficult to verify or reduce to formal criteria.

While all regions reject AI for people-related decisions, Region 1 frames this primarily as a capability issue (lack of nuance and contextual understanding), whereas Regions 2 and 3 emphasize ethical concerns such as fairness and accountability. This distinction suggests that

improving technical accuracy alone may not overcome resistance rooted in normative views.

Taken together, these insights not only highlight practical boundaries but also reinforce augmentation-based models of human-AI interaction. Across regions, managers emphasize that people-related decisions require empathy, moral judgment and accountability, qualities tightly coupled with human intuition and experience. This perspective echoes research positing that AI should augment rather than replace human judgment, particularly in decisions involving ethical stakes or social consequences (e.g. Jarrahi, 2018; Vincent, 2021; Trunk et al., 2020; Kourkoumelis et al., 2024). It also aligns with bounded rationality theory, in that respondents recognize the limits of both human and AI decisions, but differ in their views on where those limits matter most.

5.2.6 Organisational and technical constraints shape actual adoption

Despite generally high intention to use AI, actual usage is constrained by organizational and technical factors. Respondents cite confidentiality requirements, limited system integration and technical instability as reasons for restricting AI use in practice. As R2 explains: “There’s a lot of company confidential information that I should not share.” R5 notes that they “have struggled with automatization of the process”, while R8 “would love to see AI integration to [their] mails, Slack”. R9 adds: “There are often some bugs… it cannot read a doc or open a CSV file or something breaks.” While respondents in Region 2 also mention integration challenges, they persist due to high PU, whereas Region 3 reports technical issues and skepticism, amplifying adoption barriers. The findings are reinforced by the fact that perceived voluntariness is low across all regions, reflecting strict organizational guidelines regarding AI use. When AI use is perceived as mandatory, resistance can potentially increase unless governance and training are aligned. Clear policies explaining why AI is used, what decisions it supports and how accountability works are therefore central for trust and acceptance (Hao et al., 2024).

Interestingly, social influence factors, which are central in models such as TAM2, did not emerge as salient in this context. Instead, individual perceptions, technical limitations and organizational rules appear to outweigh peer or normative pressures.

Taken together, these findings indicate that AI adoption cannot be understood solely through individual attitudes or PU. Even when managers recognize AI’s potential value, adoption may

stall if organizational conditions prevent seamless integration into everyday workflows. Confidentiality rules limit what information can be shared with AI, while poor technical integration increases the effort required to use the tool effectively. As a result, AI interaction may add friction rather than reduce it, undermining PEOU and discouraging consistent usage.

From a TAM2 perspective, these organizational and technical constraints function as external variables that weaken the relationship between intention and actual usage (Venkatesh & Davis, 2000). They also interact with bounded rationality: when AI use introduces additional effort, uncertainty or risk, respondents are more likely to revert to familiar routines and heuristics rather than experiment with new tools. This underscores the socio-technical nature of AI adoption, where managers' intention to use AI does not automatically translate into sustained use unless organizational structures, integration and governance support effective decision delegation and control (Leyer & Schneider, 2021).

5.2.7 Using AI requires skill: prompting, interpretation and digital literacy

All respondents emphasize that effective AI use requires skill, particularly in prompting, interpreting outputs and refining queries. While AI tools are easy to access, extracting meaningful value demands cognitive effort, learning and experimentation. As R3 notes: "I'm learning more and more to have the correct prompts." While R8 states that "it's very difficult to explain what you want" and that they "started courses on prompt engineering", R7 describes the iterative nature of this process: "You always need to go again and again… it can take hours or even days to get to the outcome." Similarly, R2 stresses: "You really need to define what you're looking for correctly." These examples explain why PEOU remains low to moderate across regions, even among frequent users.

Region 2 illustrates how high PU can offset low PEOU. Respondents persist in using AI despite the effort costs associated with learning and refining interaction practices, because the benefits are perceived as clear and immediate. At the same time, this learning requirement introduces inequality in adoption outcomes, as managers with higher digital competence or learning agility are better positioned to benefit from AI-supported decision-making. This suggests that AI adoption is shaped not only by attitudes toward the technology, but also by users' capability to interact with it effectively.

From a theoretical perspective, this finding aligns with Leyer and Schneider's (2021) argument that managers are reluctant to delegate decision-making to AI when systems are unreliable or poorly integrated into existing workflows. Under such conditions, AI does not simplify decisions but instead introduces additional complexity, coordination effort and uncertainty. Rather than reducing cognitive load, managers must invest time in monitoring, correcting and contextualizing AI outputs, which constrains PEOU and limits the extent to which AI can be relied upon in practice.

5.2.8 The final decision remains human: intuition and experience dominate

Across all regions, managers consistently state that final decision authority remains human. AI is used to inform, structure and challenge decisions, but not to replace judgment. As R1 explains: "It's always me who defines the final [decision]." Similarly, R2 confirms: "Decision would be mine at the end." R6 states that they "never make the decision based on the output from AI", and R7 unequivocally echoes this stance: "My own intention will always override AI – 10 out of 10." This pattern is particularly evident in high-stakes, ambiguous or people-related decisions, where experience and intuition are viewed as indispensable. The statements also illustrate that, regardless of AI's analytical contribution, human judgment remains the final authority.

Comparing the three regions, critical review and override are emphasized in Region 1. Region 2 uses AI for reassurance while retaining final authority, and Region 3 expresses the strongest reliance on intuition, often framing AI as an administrative assistant (e.g. R8: "It's like a very intelligent assistant near you") rather than a decision–maker.

This finding aligns closely with dual-system theory (Kahneman, 2011). AI primarily supports analytical reasoning associated with System 2, while intuitive judgment linked to System 1 continues to guide final decisions. Rather than competing, these modes interact: AI reinforces confidence when its output aligns with intuition and prompts reflection when it does not. The persistence of intuition across regions supports augmentation-based models of human-AI interaction (Jarrahi, 2018; Vincent, 2021), indicating that even in AI-supported contexts, managerial decision-making remains fundamentally human. This resonates with research showing that expert intuition can be effective in ill-structured, ambiguous settings, where pure analytics may miss tacit or contextual nuances (Dane et al., 2012; Vincent, 2021; Sadler-Smith & Shefy, 2004). It is also consistent with Chen et al. (2023), who show that AI

explanations which complement human intuition – rather than override it – improve trust calibration and decision quality.

5.3 Practical implications

The findings suggest that organizations may consider prioritizing strategies that make AI-supported decision-making both effective and sustainable. Across all regions, managers emphasize that effective AI use depends not only on access to tools, but also on the ability to formulate prompts correctly and interpret outputs accurately. When respondents struggle to find the “right question” (R3), they report frustration and may even “give up” (R2, R3). In line with Leyer and Schneider (2021), this highlights the need for training that combines prompting literacy with interpretation skills to reduce effort costs and improve PEOU.

Moreover, these findings are consistent with prior research showing that individuals with a better understanding of AI are more likely to perceive greater benefits from its use, and that perceived benefits strongly motivate trust in AI (e.g. Gillespie et al., 2023). Organizations could therefore complement technical training with conceptual guidance that explains when AI is appropriate to use, how to assess its outputs and where human oversight remains essential.

Practical interventions may also reflect regional differences observed in this study. In contexts where PU is high but PEOU remains low, as in Region 2, organizations could focus on reducing cognitive effort through careful tool selection, better integration into existing workflows and targeted skills development. In regions where skepticism persists, such as Region 3, the priority should be strengthening demonstrability and transparency at the organizational level. Transparency significantly increases appropriate trust, but, as Wang et al. (2023) emphasize, verification and calibrated reliance remain crucial. Nevertheless, measures that make AI use more traceable and accountable can reduce uncertainty and help close the gap between perceived potential and actual usage behavior (Hao et al., 2024; Eisbach et al., 2023; Chen et al., 2023).

Designing for calibrated trust is particularly important (Eisbach et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2023). Eisbach et al. (2023) emphasize that poorly calibrated trust, whether too high or too low, can harm decision quality. Organizational practices could therefore encourage critical engagement with AI outputs rather than passive acceptance, for example by establishing

verification routines, peer review of AI-supported decisions, or explicit accountability norms. Chen et al. (2023) similarly argue that explanation design should complement human reasoning and intuition rather than override it, supporting appropriate reliance in AI-assisted decision-making.

Finally, while AI can reduce cognitive burden and reinforce analytical thinking, as Hao et al. (2024) observe, this benefit comes with risks. Several respondents express concern about over-reliance and the potential erosion of critical thinking (e.g. R1, R7, R8, R9), a risk echoed in recent research on cognitive atrophy from excessive AI use (e.g. Kosmyna et al., 2025). Organizations could address these concerns by reinforcing human accountability and maintaining decision practices that require reflection and justification beyond AI output. Measures such as mandatory validation steps, reflective questioning or periodic restrictions on AI use for certain tasks can help balance efficiency gains with the preservation of managerial judgment, learning and adaptability.

6. Conclusion

6.1 Main conclusions

The purpose of this study was to explore similarities and differences in how managers across different regions view and engage with AI in their daily decision-making processes. By integrating qualitative interview data with descriptive results from the statements and applying a combined theoretical framework, this thesis provides a nuanced understanding of how AI is perceived and used in a global organizational context.

Taken together, the findings show that AI is primarily used as a managerial augmentation tool rather than a decision-maker. Across all regions, managers rely on AI to support data-intensive, time-pressured or analytically complex decisions, where it helps reduce cognitive load and expand the set of considered alternatives. However, final decision authority consistently remains human, particularly in people-related or ethically sensitive decisions, where experience, intuition and contextual judgment are viewed as indispensable.

The results also demonstrate that PU is the dominant driver of AI adoption, consistent with TAM2. Managers in this study continue to use AI even when PEOU is low, provided that outputs are reliable, demonstrable and clearly relevant to their tasks. Where output quality and result demonstrability are weak, PU declines and adoption stalls. Trust therefore emerges as a central mediating factor: AI is trusted conditionally and requires verification, and sustained use depends on the managers' ability to calibrate trust appropriately.

Notably, social influence factors, which are prominent in TAM2, were largely absent in the respondents' reasoning. This suggests that AI adoption in this context is shaped more by technical or individual perceptions than by normative pressures.

Regional differences are evident but do not reflect fundamentally different attitudes toward AI. Instead, they are best understood through differences in perceived output quality, trust and actual usage behavior. Managers in regions with higher PU and demonstrable benefits report higher usage despite effort costs, whereas skepticism persists where AI outputs are perceived as unreliable. Across all regions, intuition remains central, and AI is most readily accepted when it aligns with managers' existing judgments rather than contradicts them.

By combining TAM2 with theories of bounded rationality and intuitive decision-making, this thesis contributes a combined model that captures both rational evaluations of technology and the cognitive realities of managerial decision-making. The findings show that technology acceptance and human judgment do not operate independently, but interact dynamically in practice. AI adoption in managerial contexts is therefore best understood not as a purely technological or behavioral phenomenon, but as a socio-cognitive process in which analytical support and human intuition coexist.

6.2 Limitations

While this study provides valuable insights into how managers engage with AI in decision-making, several limitations should be acknowledged.

First, the study is based on a small qualitative sample consisting of nine managers within a single global technology company. Although this allowed for rich, in-depth exploration of experiences and perceptions, the findings are not statistically generalizable. The results should therefore be interpreted as analytically rather than statistically generalizable, offering conceptual insights that may be transferable to similar organizational contexts rather than representative of all managers or industries.

Second, the focus on one organizational setting limits the ability to decouple regional or cultural influences from company-specific factors. All respondents operate under the same corporate AI guidelines, governance structures and technological infrastructure, which may shape attitudes and usage patterns. While this design strengthens internal comparability across regions, it also means that some observed similarities or differences may be driven by organizational context rather than broader regional or cultural factors.

Third, the study relies on self-reported data collected through interviews and statements. As with all self-reported measures, responses may be influenced by social desirability bias, selective recall or respondents' own interpretations of their behavior. Although efforts were made to mitigate this through open-ended questioning and triangulation with quantitative indicators, actual AI usage behavior may differ from reported practices.

Fourth, the study adopts a cross-sectional design, capturing managerial attitudes and

behaviors at a single point in time. Given the rapid evolution of generative AI tools and organizational practices, perceptions of usefulness, trust and ease of use may change as systems improve and managers gain experience.

Additionally, the way usage behavior was operationalized may have influenced the aggregated results. In particular, several respondents in Region 1 reported no use of AI for people-related decisions, which lowered the overall usage behavior score, even though these respondents described frequent use of AI for other tasks such as data analysis and decision preparation. Consequently, lower usage scores in this region should be interpreted with caution, as they may reflect task-specific boundaries rather than reduced overall engagement with AI.

Finally, while the combined theoretical model integrates TAM2 with bounded rationality and intuitive decision-making, it remains conceptual and exploratory in nature. The model was not tested quantitatively, and causal relationships between its components cannot be empirically confirmed within the scope of this study. As such, the model should be viewed as a framework for understanding and guiding future research rather than as a definitive explanatory model.

6.3 Future research

This study contributes to existing research by proposing and empirically applying a combined theoretical model that integrates TAM2 with theories of bounded rationality and intuitive decision-making. To capture the multifaceted nature of managerial AI adoption, the study employed a broad thematic structure. The eight themes identified through the analysis reflect the model's ambition to account for both rational technology acceptance mechanisms and the cognitive, contextual and experiential dimensions of managerial decision-making. Rather than indicating conceptual overlap, the breadth of themes was necessary to capture the complexity of AI-supported decision-making and to support the model's scalability across contexts.

Future research could build on this contribution in several ways. First, the combined model could be applied and tested in different industries, organizational structures or cultural contexts to examine its external validity. Given that the model accommodates multiple decision-making dimensions, it is particularly suited for comparative studies across settings characterized by varying levels of risk, uncertainty and ethical considerations. Such research

could also assess whether the same thematic structure emerges or whether additional themes become salient in other contexts.

Second, future studies could extend the combined framework by incorporating constructs that emerged from the qualitative analysis but are not formally represented in our model. For example, trust repeatedly appeared as a central factor shaping how managers engage with AI recommendations, particularly under conditions of bounded rationality. Exploring how trust interacts with PU, PEOU, intuition and actual AI use could further strengthen the framework's explanatory power and theoretical contribution.

Third, quantitative or mixed-methods research could operationalize our combined model and its expanded set of constructs to test relationships at scale. Longitudinal designs would be especially valuable for examining how reliance on intuition, trust in AI and perceptions of usefulness evolve over time as managers gain experience with AI systems. Moreover, such studies could investigate whether social influence factors become more prominent as AI adoption matures. Despite their central role in TAM2, respondents rarely referenced peer or organizational pressure. This could indicate that AI adoption in this context is shaped more by individual, technical or structural conditions than by social dynamics. Alternatively, it may reflect the early stages of AI adoption, where organizational norms and expectations are still forming.

Finally, future research could explore how organizational and design-related factors, such as explainability, governance structures and AI usage policies, interact with the cognitive processes captured by the model. Given the consistent finding that AI augments rather than replaces managerial judgment, further work could examine how different forms of AI explanations and feedback mechanisms support effective human–AI collaboration.

Overall, the combined model and its associated thematic structure provide a flexible and extensible framework for future research. By allowing for the integration of additional constructs and themes, the model offers a scalable foundation for advancing understanding of AI-supported decision-making in organizational contexts.

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Appendix A: Questionnaire

Statements

Bounded rationality:

Time constraints

1. I rarely make decisions under time pressure.
2. AI allows me to make faster decisions without sacrificing quality.
3. Deadlines often prevent me from exploring every feasible alternative.

Cognitive limitations

4. I often find the number of factors I must consider in daily decisions to be overwhelming.
5. If I have to make a complex decision, AI makes it easier for me.
6. When situations are complex, I focus on the most important information rather than analyzing every detail.

Incomplete information

7. In my daily work, I rarely have access to all the information I would ideally need to make a decision.
8. When I need to decide before all facts are fully available, I can rely on AI to make a good call.
9. AI often helps me identify relevant information to make decisions.

Intuitive decision-making:

Past experience

10. I tend to sense the right course of action before analyzing all information when making a decision.
11. When using AI, I still rely heavily on my own experience to evaluate its recommendations.
12. Even with AI support, I consider my experience as the final guide in decision-making.

Pattern recognition

13. I tend to spot meaningful patterns that AI would overlook.
14. In complex decisions, AI often picks up the same subtle signals as I do.
15. I rely on patterns I can identify when making decisions rather than on AI-generated recommendations.

Instinct / "gut feeling"

16. When my intuition conflicts with AI's suggestions, I question my judgment.
17. I feel more confident in my intuitive decisions if AI points in the same direction.
18. I trust AI in the context of decision-making as much as I trust my gut feeling.

TAM2 questions

Usage behavior

19. AI is part of my daily work to support my decision-making.
20. I use AI to support decision-making in my everyday tasks.

21. I use AI to support decision-making in people-related topics (HR).
22. I use AI to support decision-making related to KPIs, data analysis or performance metrics.
23. I use AI to support decision-making in complex or ambiguous situations.

Intention to use

24. Given that I have access to AI in my job, I intend to use it to support decision-making.

Perceived Ease of Use

25. Interacting with AI in my decision-making process requires a lot of my mental effort.
26. I find AI to be easy to use for decision-making.
27. I find it difficult to get AI to do what I want it to do in the context of decision-making.

Perceived Usefulness

28. Using AI improves how I perform when I make decisions in my job.
29. Using AI makes the outcomes significantly better when I make decisions.
30. Using AI increases my confidence in decision-making processes.
31. I find AI to be useful for decision-making in my job.

Subjective norm

32. People who are important to me think that I should use AI to support my decision-making.

Voluntariness

33. My employer does not require me to use AI.
34. Although it might be helpful, using AI is not compulsory in my job.

Image

35. People in my organization who use AI to make decisions have more prestige than those who do not.
36. In my role, I believe I would be perceived as more competent if I use AI regularly to make decisions.

Job relevance

37. In my job, usage of AI is very relevant for decision-making.
38. In my job, usage of AI can have a real impact on decision-making.

Output Quality

39. The quality of the output I get from AI is high.
40. AI provides reliable outputs to support decision-making in my role.
41. I consider decision outcomes supported by AI to be inferior to those achieved without AI usage.

Result Demonstrability

42. The results of using AI to support the decision-making process are apparent to me.
43. It is clear to me when AI has improved decision outcomes.
44. I would find it difficult to explain the benefits of using AI in decision-making to others.

Open-ended questions

Bounded rationality & Intuitive decision-making:

1. What shortcuts or strategies do you use when making decisions with AI in situations with limited time and/or information?
2. In what types of decisions do you trust AI the most, and how do your own judgment or intuition influence situations where you might override or reinterpret AI's recommendations?

Perceived Usefulness & Perceived Ease of Use:

3. How do you personally define a 'useful' contribution from AI in your decision-making process?
4. How easy or difficult is it for you to integrate AI into your decision-making process, including any challenges you face?

Intention to use:

5. How do you see your use of AI in decision-making evolving over time; are there any particular opportunities or concerns you anticipate?
6. What motivates you – or discourages you – to keep using AI in your daily work for decision-making?

Usage behavior:

7. Can you walk us through how AI fits into how you make decisions?
8. How do you decide when to use AI and when not to, and what kinds of decisions do you typically involve AI in versus those you avoid using AI for?

Appendix B: Statement responses

	North	North	North	Central	Central	Central	East	East	East
Item	**R1**	**R2**	**R3**	**R4**	**R5**	**R6**	**R7**	**R8**	**R9**
1*	2→4	3	3	1→5	3	4→2	2→4	1→5	2→4
2	2	3	2	4	4	5	2	3	4
3	1	4	2	4	3	3	3	5	4
4	1	4	4	3	3	4	3	4	2
5	3	4	3	5	4	5	1	2	3
6	4	3	4	2	5	5	4	4	5
7	2	2	3	2	4	4	3	1	2
8	2	2	4	2	4	2	2	1	1
9	4	4	4	4	4	3	4	3	3
10	4	3	4	5	4	3	5	4	4
11	5	4	4	5	5	5	5	5	5
12	5	5	5	4	4	5	5	5	4
13	5	3	3	4	3	3	5	2	3
14*	2→4	2→4	2→4	3	3	2→4	3	1→5	3
15	4	3	2	4	4	3	3	5	4
16*	2→4	2→4	2→4	3	5→1	5→1	2→4	4→2	2→4
17	4	4	4	5	4	5	5	4	4
18*	1→5	2→4	3	2→4	3	4→2	1→5	1→5	3
19	4	3	3	5	4	5	2	2	4
20	3	3	2	5	4	3	2	2	4
21	1	1	2	4	2	5	1	1	1
22	5	4	4	4	4	2	4	3	4
23	3	3	5	4	4	4	2	1	3
24	5	5	4	5	5	5	3	3	4
25*	1→5	5→1	2→4	2→4	4→2	4→2	2→4	2→4	3
26	5	3	3	3	3	3	3	1	4

27*	2→4	5→1	3	3	3	3	3	5→1	4→2
28	4	4	3	4	4	5	2	2	4
29	4	3	3	3	4	4	3	2	2
30	3	4	4	4	5	5	2	1	3
31	5	4	4	5	4	5	3	1	4
32	4	1	5	2	4	3	5	2	3
33	1	1	1	1	2	2	1	1	1
34	1	1	1	2	2	2	2	2	2
35	4	2	2	4	4	1	5	4	3
36	4	2	4	4	4	2	5	3	3
37	4	4	4	5	4	5	4	2	4
38	5	4	4	5	3	3	3	2	4
39	4	3	3	3	4	3	4	1	3
40	4	3	3	3	4	4	3	1	3
41*	2→4	2→4	3	2→4	3	4→2	3	5→1	3
42	4	3	4	4	4	3	3	2	4
43	4	4	4	3	4	4	3	2	4
44*	1→5	1→5	2→4	1→5	1→5	1→5	1→5	5→1	2→4

** reversed item (a score of "1" indicates high agreement with the underlying construct)*

Appendix C: Coding of interviews

Respondent 1 (North)

Excerpt	Code
“You can really optimize your time”; “It is super smart and quick”	**Time-saving and efficiency**
“I’ve basically set it up as my sparring partner”; “It challenges me to think out of the box”	**AI as sparring partner**
“I make my AI to analyze some data for me and give me some trends”	**AI for data analysis**
“I don’t fully trust it”; “No matter the question… I always review it and don’t blindly trust it”; “It’s important for me to challenge what I get”; “It’s super important for me to be critical”; “You cannot really trust whatever it gives you”	**Critical review and non-blind trust**
“It’s a lot of back-and-forth sparring before I then in the end have come to… the way I need to go”; “Challenge it back”	**Iterative back-and-forth process**
“Push my creativity”; “Give me examples of how I could have done differently”; “It gives me some new contributions to how I could have done”	**Creativity and alternative perspectives**
“It’s always me who defines the final [decision]”; “I always to some extent override what it gives me”	**Human judgment remains final**
“Important for me to train it to be as close as myself”; “You need to describe for it in the very beginning ‘who am I’, ‘what are my responsibilities’”	**Training and personalization**
“Smaller text-based or communication-based tasks I do trust it”; “When it’s more data-driven, it’s always to look it through”	**Task-specific trust**
“Now it’s fairly easy for me… but in the beginning it was quite like, where do I start, how does it really work?”; “From the beginning it’s not easy”	**Learning curve**
“How can I utilize the AI to automate reports for me?”	**Opportunities: automation and efficiency**
“I think… basic things – just do it yourself so you don’t lose the creativity”; “You get kind of stupid”; “It’s become a bit dangerous because it is so easy”; “You… become a robot if you don’t think yourself”	**Concern about over-reliance/cognitive dependency and loss of creativity**
“You should not rely fully on AI… should I terminate or keep this person”; “Don’t trust that	**Ethical boundaries for sensitive decisions**

fully when it comes to those kind of really big and human decisions”	

Respondent 2 (North)

Excerpt	Code
“AI just puts it on my table summarized beautifully”; “It took seconds”; “My main motivation of using AI is time-saving”	**Time-saving and efficiency**
“Give me a concrete summary”; “Summarize pile of information real quick”	**Information summarization and search**
“I would mostly trust the hard data”; “More soft topics, like HR ones, people-related ones – I would take advice… but decide myself”	**Trust in hard data vs. soft topics**
“Decision would be mine at the end”; “I trust my own experience a little bit more… it’s not human, it can’t properly consider people’s feelings”	**Human judgment remains final**
“You really need to define what you’re looking for correctly”; “One thing that needs to be avoided with talking to AI is being biased”; “I need to approach AI as neutrally as possible if I want a proper, objective outcome”	**Need for clear instructions and neutrality**
“There’s a lot of company confidential information that I should not share”; “Sometimes it does not understand what I want from it”; “There have been times when I just give up”; “It’s not advanced enough yet… it really needs a lot of guidance”	**Challenges: confidentiality and limitations**
“Sometimes I just don’t think of… using AI”; “I’m used to relying on myself and my decisions”	**Habit barrier**
“I started exploring it… the more I realized it can do, the more I started using it”; “I’m still getting used to using it”	**Curiosity and gradual adoption**
“AI actually could free time for us”; “I’m trying to stay optimistic”	**Optimism about AI’s future**
“If I don’t have anyone to talk to or I need a second opinion – a neutral one – I would reach out to AI for advice”	**AI as a neutral advisor/second opinion**
“It’s still not as human… it’s starting to get there… but it will take years of research… to really get there”	**Expectation of emotional intelligence development**

Respondent 3 (North)

Excerpt	Code
“I normally use AI when it’s very short in time for extracting or making sense of a dataset”;	**AI for heavy lifting in data tasks**

“Without me doing the heavy lifting in terms of adding or computing things”	
“I need the answer now and I need to defend my choices now”	**Time-saving and efficiency**
“Explain like I’m five”; “Makes it more visual so then my decision-making… gets better”	**Simplifying complex language**
“Data-related decision-making or analysis of data”	**Trust in AI for data-related decisions**
“AI can say… is the best worker… but I know she shows up late”; “The nuances of human behavior, AI doesn’t have it”	**Override when human factors matter**
“There was a gut feeling in me that there was something wrong with the numbers”; “It took months before I was able to prove that my gut feel was correct”	**Gut feeling as override trigger**
“I usually use AI to give me possible scenarios… and then you are able to take a risk that is more calculated”	**AI as scenario generator**
“AI would allow me to really question my own choices”; “That’s where it becomes more useful for me to decide between candidate A and B”; “Even if I know the subject matter and I’m still insecure about the answer… I need to maybe ask AI if this sounds correct”	**AI as decision challenger/sparring partner**
“AI will suggest to me that ‘hey, this is what you should do next week and cancel this investment thing’”; “It’s like a personal assistant of some sort”	**AI as personal assistant**
“You’re making a… very objective decision”; “At the very least I am sure of the risk I’m taking”	**Objectivity and risk awareness**
“There’s also some red flags that AI doesn’t really understand”; “In the final steps of an interview I ask very challenging questions… AI doesn’t know that that happened but I saw it myself”	**AI blind spots and red flags**
“I would say in between, because my relationship with AI is not so long so sometimes we don’t understand each other”; “It will take time for me to be fluent”	**Integration moderately easy**
“I get frustrated that it’s giving me… data interpretation that I have already thought about myself”; “What I’m trying to ask AI is to give me something more meaty”	**Frustration with basic answers**
“I’m learning more and more to have the correct prompts”; “If I give the right prompts, it gives me actually meaningful information”; “Ask the right questions so you get the right answers”	**Learning curve and prompting skills**

“I want to learn how to use both ChatGPT and Gemini and also… other platforms”; “I hope not to be dependent on one”	**Desire for multi-platform fluency**
“I did use AI… during my application… because I understood… that my ‘competitors’ will answer what AI is giving me… so I made sure that my answer had the human touch”	**Early adoption for competitive advantage**
“I see it as in the future when I learn more or I ask for more training to help automate certain data points”; “I will be using it more and more once I become more fluent”	**Future expectation: automation and fluency**
“The concern is time… how do I make time to actually have the fluency”; “Sometimes you need to have coding language and I’m super basic in that”	**Concern: time to learn and coding skills**
“I’m just fascinated by it in general”; “Opportunities are more apparent to me in terms of time-saving”	**Motivation: fascination and potential**
“If I’m not given enough time and I cannot ask the right question… then it actually doesn’t do anything and I give up”	**Discouragement: lack of time for proper prompting**
“I use AI mainly for subject matters that I am either insecure about or I want to learn more”	**Decision fit: unfamiliar or insecure topics**
“If we have some sort of HR case… AI will not be able to help me with it”; “A lot of the human-ness… it won’t be the first option for me”	**Boundaries for human-centric decisions**

Respondent 4 (Central)

Excerpt	Code
“I usually use it firstly to gather those informations which I’m lacking”; “Ask it to let me know about any information I would maybe not even look for”	**AI for filling knowledge gaps**
“The time which I would use to actually look those informations up”; “I just want to save time for everyone”; “Saving a bunch of time”	**Time-saving strategy**
“Making sure that I actually considered every aspect of it”; “I ask if… there might be any other things which I haven’t considered yet”	**Ensuring completeness**
“When it’s about laws or legislation, about some topics which I’m aware I don’t know exactly, I think I trust AI the most”; “Especially when it has all the relevant links”	**Trust in AI for factual/legal topics**
“If it doesn’t [have links], I ask it to back it up with some official websites”; “I can feel from how it is phrased that it is bulls**t”	**Conditional trust and verification**
“When it’s… about behaviors of people which I know I have the experience in then I might not	

even ask"; "When it is not that information-based topic… I will decide"	**Selective reliance based on experience**
"Sometimes just for… curiosity or fun, I just ask about things… I could answer myself"; "It's very interesting…. how it develops from week to week"	**Curiosity and experimentation**
"A year ago… I didn't really trust it… I start trusting it more and more"	**Growing trust over time**
"Helps me explore some parts… I might not think about"; "I usually ask… 'is there any other points which you would consider that I haven't'"; Whenever there is a slight doubt that…. I could use a point of view or any reassurance… I use it always"	**Useful contribution: new perspectives and reassurance**
"I'm just… blindsighted… and if I would be super objective which I think we can never be… it helps me… step two steps back"; "I'm just so used to the same numbers… that it might help think a bit more objectively"	**Objectivity and bias reduction**
"When the decision-making process includes data analysis, then without a doubt that is super useful"	**Data analysis as clear value**
"I would say it is very easy"; "I don't really stress about it"; "It is… included already in the email programs"; "In Zoom meetings when it's summarizing it for you afterwards"	**Integration and ease of use**
"I won't make… firing someone as a decision just based on AI"; "It's more of a supporting role"	**AI as supporting role, not decision-maker**
"I used to use it only occasionally"; "Now I open it on a daily basis"; "I didn't really use it when I thought I didn't have enough time to… give it enough information so it can help me – that has changed a lot; I really quickly put down… something… it might not be enough for it to give me the correct answer but then I can refine that"	**Daily use and growing scope**
"Scheduling of the stores which might be a dream to come true"; "Still loads of parts of our jobs where it is not used yet"	**Anticipated opportunities**
"When… my team… will use it… we might need to micromanage a bit"; "Everyone would trust it… in a different level… so we would need to oversee for some time, like 'hey, you made this decision based on this or that but have you backed it up or do you… trust it fully'"	**Concern about over-reliance and micromanagement**
"Our assignments are put together in a way that ChatGPT can easily do"; "We might… need to transform the way we are interviewing	

people… we need to rely on situational questions which has to be answered from your own thoughts”	**Concern about recruitment and authenticity**
“[For scheduling], it would… need so much time… to prompt it and set it up”; “Nobody has that dedicated time”	**Effort required for complex tasks**
“I usually don’t consider myself super creative, but that can… show me some very nice ways of putting out a one-pager”	**Creativity boost - motivation**
“I cannot tell you anything which would stop me from keep using it”	**No significant discouragement**
“When I was driving to work I wanted to… put together an agenda and I just used it as a… personal assistant… I used the voice function and talked through where we are at right now”; “I just used it like that to think out loud”	**AI as personal assistant for planning**
“I might ask it and then it tells me A or B and then I’m relieved that might be the good answer… or it says B and now I’m disappointed and probably I wanted to decide on the other one”; “I was a bit conflicted… and [challenged it back]”	**AI as decision-testing tool/occasional sparring partner**
“I avoid… using it… when it’s super serious…when I know I need to include HR or payroll… then I wouldn’t ask it… I wouldn’t rely on it at the end so why ask”; “I didn’t even think about asking AI about [theft investigation]”	**Boundaries for serious decisions**

Respondent 5 (Central)

Excerpt	Code
“Framing is the answer… giving more data and decrease time in conversation"; “Two or three chats I have an answer… in ten minutes instead of one hour”	**Structured framing for efficiency and time reduction**
“Beside framing I use a deep dive as well… in parallel, meaning framing and in parallel communication on several roles”	**Parallel use of AI for multitasking**
“I gave him a role… a procurement role to negotiate for the price”; “I get an expert role for deep dive, so for example you are the procurement for the paper in Serbia and give me all the relevant informations for the negotiations”	**Role-based prompting for expertise**
“Sometimes… he forgot something we briefed him before yesterday in the same chat… so it’s like you need to be focused”	**Caution about AI forgetting context**

“In analytics, data let’s say analysis, I trust him”; “I rely more on business decisions, numbers, figures and not related to people”	**Trust and reliance on AI for analytics and data, not people**
“I challenge the answer”; “Deep dive… is super important and ultra valuable”	**Challenging AI’s answers**
“Decision-making [has] three pillars… my experience – levering my strengths – experts [and] AI”; “AI is not the first pillar”; “Most of decisions… are on my own or on my own plus AI”	**Decision-making pillars: human judgment first, AI as secondary support**
“Support in decision-making… giving the perspective – sometimes I get a perspective that… never probably comes on my mind… and the data analysis”; “If I have time I like to challenge myself in terms of ‘how you would do this’ and this is the adding perspective momentum”; “Places where you are good…. there’s the room for improvement to ask AI”	**Useful contribution: support, new perspectives and data analysis**
“Time… is the biggest gain”; “Saving time is a skill honestly”; “In the total it saved our time in decision-making because we don’t have each time [human] experts now”; “Output is time-saving”	**Time-saving as core value**
“It was easy for me”; “Now I find very easy and spread my experience”; “I have a struggle with my people and team”; “I’m finding difficult for the others to spread it better but for me it was easier”	**Easy integration for self, harder for team**
“It depends of learning agility of the person, that’s personal skill and personal capability”; That’s learning agility capability and we are different”	**Learning agility matters**
“I want to have live [availability] and he refused… it’s not possible now”; “I’m facing as a challenge… automatization in a job”	**Current challenge: finding new areas for automation**
“I have struggled with automatization of the process… it could help a lot”; “Opportunity is where and when and how to use more in terms of new areas”	**Opportunities: process automation and broader integration**
“Motivating everything I said already… support and data analysis and giving perspectives”	**Motivation: efficiency and perspective**
“The energies I need to invest to spread… awareness of using AI within my team”	**Discouragement: effort to spread adoption**
“I’m not using it… [for] repetitive defined-by-procedure decisions”; “I’m definitely using it when… I’m not feeling very much comfort in a knowledge… or experience way, or I don’t have expert beside me”; “Every hard decision… AI is there… for the most…	**Decision fit: avoid repetitive tasks, use for complex decisions**

common, basic decisions – no, but for the middle and the harder… more complex, he's there"	
"I did it for salaries, but soft HR – no… So far, I'm not saying I will not, but I did not"	**Occasional use for HR-related numbers, not soft HR**

Respondent 6 (Central)

Excerpt	Code
"It's useful to confirm my opinion but I never make the decision based on the output from the AI"; "Always I'm using AI to help me with decisions"; "I'm checking this with AI and if I have same opinion or same experience then it's much more easier for me to clarify my decision"; "I think it's the perfect tool but it's not something that will change my experience or knowledge"; "It's never like that I will do the decision based on the AI, never"; "If… I'm just asking the AI to check it and AI just confirming, then it's like second opinion I take it"; "Confirming my opinion and knowledge… I just want to only see the opinion of second side and… that's the AI perfect for this one"; "It's always good to have second opinion"	**AI as decision support and second opinion, never the decider**
"AI is the tool which is giving me more time, so in a quicker way I can just find what I'm searching for"; "To really find the things which I am not able to find quickly on the internet"	**Time-saving and quicker overview**
"If this is related to some very clear things, for example… laws… then it's much easier for me"; "If… I think there is a clear statement that could be searched… I trust to the AI"; "I will never trust to the AI in the areas which I'm not sure that this is something only the AI need to search"; "Clear [areas] like the HR topics, payroll topics or some low topics… that's quite easy because it's searchable"; "The analytic one… is also okay because that's the numbers"; "If I'm asking about some complex situation… I'm very, very careful about the output from the AI"; "If I need to do some planning… I'm more using my expertise and Excels to just calculate it… I tried [AI] a few times… the answer is not a good one"	**Task-specific trust and analytical boundaries (clear/searchable/factual vs. complex/multi-factor)**
"90% is based on my intuition… if I have a different opinion than AI… I'm using 90% my opinion so I'm not going to check it"	**Human judgment/intuition overrides**
"You should not ask that you already give some purpose of your expected answer… because the	

AI see that you're going this direction so I will just go this direction"; "You should put all the information… in a neutral way"; "I'm asking then I get the response so then I'm asking from a different way and checking what is the answer now… and then probably I start to be confident if the answer is still the same"; "Usually AI is providing your expected answer, not… the relevant one"	**Prompting neutrality and triangulation (avoid leading)**
"Not make from AI the Google so not to search only the information which is possible to find on the Google… but if there is more complex questions so then I'm just using the AI"; "Is it a simple request and it's going to the Google but if I'm asking… what kind of sales increase I can expect… then I'm asking AI for the calculation"	**Google vs AI task separation**
"I always check the calculation by my own calculation [to] find if we are on the same page"; "I always want to see it by myself from my calculation"	**Verification and plausibility checks**
"Where I trust to the AI for 100% is that I'm asking that what should be the formula in Excel to calculate… in this case I know that it's super easy and then I trust, then I'm not checking it is correct"	**Rule/formula trust (bounded domain certainty)**
"Now [integration] is very easy because I start using it on a daily basis… but before this there was quite a long period to teach the AI"; "The trust is still not there but it's on much more better level"; "I teach my AI to say that 'I'm not sure, I'm not able to provide the results… then you can a little bit more rely on this one"; "We are building the trust to each other"; "Still I cannot imagine that… in two years I will be able to just go with the response of the AI as a decision for something which is really important"	**Trust trajectory and personalization, trust calibration**
"Should I open a market in the city? I will never ask AI about this one"; "What I'm avoiding definitely is… things which really matter… if you go to divorce… it's a tough topic so then I will not use the AI"	**Boundaries: high-stakes/sensitive decisions**
"The motivation is to save the time… help me to find the things how I will then decide"	**Motivation: time-saving and better inputs**
"That these machines… will start to talk to each other… could be the concern of me… you will not get the right answer because they don't want to give you the right answer"; "People will start to rely on the response from the AI,	

which means they will start to do bad decisions”	**Concern about over-reliance and autonomy**
“I’m trying the AI every day for… different questions and task… I want to see the opinion of the AI”	**Use for exploration/curiosity**

Respondent 7 (East)

Excerpt	Code
“I’m using other people’s prompts… I’m ‘stealing’ prompts from others… I’m like‘you did it, so give it’”; “Everything is very similar… someone probably already experienced that”	**Prompt borrowing/reuse**
“I also have subjects in the AI… he knows the way that I think in every subject”; “I split it to different subjects… if it’s work, if it’s scheduling…”	**Personalization using “subjects”**
“You always need to focus him for what you really want from him”	**Need to steer/focus AI**
“Mainly when it comes to analyze metrics and data… that’s the main thing”; “For HR… I will ask him to summarize… but I will not take an HR decision according to AI”	**Trust calibrated by task**
“It’s more to prepare myself to the decision than making it through what AI recommend to me”	**Preparation vs. decision**
“My own intuition will always override AI – 10 out of 10”	**Human judgment/intuition overrides**
“He can recommend five employees… but I know sometimes I can put four because these four are working like six”	**Tacit/local knowledge in staffing**
“It will never have the full picture… you’re wasting a lot of time to give the full picture”; “We don’t need a computer… to take decisions about people’s life”	**Human factors gap**
“It’s easier just to take the decision than start to write him… I don’t need to explain myself to him when I know what’s the right decision to take”	**Friction cost to contextualize**
“AI will put a red flag… look at that data… small details can disappear from your eye… AI is here to say notice it’s there”	**AI as salience amplifier**
“You always need to go again and again… it can take hours or even days to get to the outcome”	**Iterative prompting burden**
“You’re working hard for a few hours, but then it saves you in the long term”	**Front-loaded effort leads to long-term time-saving**

“Sometimes it’s very easy… sometimes it’s like a process”	**Integration both easy and difficult (“in the middle”)**
“It really depends… how this decision is heavy… then I will look to be more precise”	**Decision-weight sensitivity**
“I’m a bit concerned… the human part will fade away… you should use AI to help you, but not… be the guideline”	**Concern about over-reliance**
“It does not control me, I control it”; “If you don’t have Wi-Fi, you don’t have your best friend”	**Agency/control stance**
“When there is something new, you want to know about it, you explore a lot”; “You want to have the knowledge… if I put an effort and I have the right prompt I will save time later”	**Curiosity and motivation to learn**
“Maybe in the beginning mainly and some during… but when you need to sign it, that will be me”	**Process placement (early-stage use)**
“When it comes to HR subjects – no, hard data – yes”	**Task selection rule**

Respondent 8 (East)

Excerpt	Code
“Maximum… to make my mail more official… to translate something”; “I will use AI… [for] the most simple decisions… very basic decisions”; “It’s mostly to have some data or maybe… to clarify something”	**AI for basic or routine tasks only**
“I don’t use AI for decision-making at all”; “Today’s AI… it’s not work useful”; “ChatGPT is better for fun than for work”; “The support of the AI for decision-making is… very low”; “For now [usefulness]... it’s not even 1%”	**AI not useful for decision-making**
“The results I get from the AI makes me to work more”; “AI adds time… especially when we give feedbacks”	**AI adds time instead of saving time**
“Most AIs… are lying”; “The information you get from the AI is not always true”; “They are lying a lot”; “I asked for the sources”; “Even the links… it lies a lot”; “ChatGPT will write down 100 fake sources from different books which are not exist even in the world”; “I am avoiding to using AI from the stuff I have no idea because I could not check it, if true or not true”; “The main question is the trust – if they will stop lying I will trust them”	**Trust and accuracy concerns**
“It’s very difficult to explain AI what you want from it”; “It’s difficult to explain to AI with prompts”	**Prompting challenges**

“I would love to see AI integration to our tools… our mails, Slack”; “Usage of Gemini in the Google Sheet is very bad for now”	**Desire for better integration**
“I will get the AI result… then I will decide from my judgment”	**Human judgment dominates AI use**
“It’s like a very intelligent assistant near you”; “It’s like a assistant near you to help you to get more time for other job”	**AI as an assistant**
“I totally don’t use AI for any decision-making, but I use AI [to give] feedback to the store managers…to think about is this sentence good to use or wrong to use etc.”; “Decision is already made and it helps only to move forward with this decision as fast as possible”	**Post-decision usage of AI**
“There are a lot of side effects which AI will not consider and… will not understand”; “Totally against it… people-related decisions are not for the AI for now”	**Avoids AI for complex or human-centric decisions**
“Maybe in the future… some versions… are much more helpful regarding the data, strategy etc.”; “Probably it will take at least 30% of my daily work”; “All data work the AI will take from me – it will be very useful”; “I’m waiting for the AI for the future, I’m waiting data analyze work”	**Future expectation of usefulness**
“The biggest plus is the time”; “The biggest motivation for the AI is… it gives you time”	**Motivation: time-saving and innovation potential**
“I have some doubts regarding the future of AI that will make our brains to work less; “AI will replace the brain work – that… could be dangerous in the future if they don’t limit it”	**Concern about cognitive dependency**
“I was thinking my prompt engineering is not enough”; “That’s why I start to get some online courses… and I saw I am not on the wrong way… I see ChatGPT is lying, the AI is not in the level as I am waiting”	**Skill development attempts and perceived limitations**

Respondent 9 (East)

Excerpt	Code
“It’s much faster to just screenshot and send… instead of downloading it into a CSV file or a Google Sheet link”; “When you’re overwhelmed with tasks… you kind of don’t have another choice – you just need to use it because you don’t have time”	**Time-saving shortcuts**
“I don’t rely on it to make decisions for me, I just want it to organize my data better and faster… then I make the decision myself”; “A very smart, very fast assistant”; “I try to only	

use it for complex things that need analyzing multiple inputs"; "I would use it to get to know a topic better for sure"	**AI as analytical assistant, not a decider**
"Usually it's data analysis"; "99% of time it's numbers-related"; "It helps me analyze the trends"; "I give it a scenario and it runs it, calculates it"; "I use it for… computational decisions"	**Numbers-related trust and use cases**
"I don't use the word intuition much… I'd rather base stuff on my previous experience… or the data I have in front of me"; "I treat it as an assistant, as a tool… but in the end it's always my judgment – I never ask it 'should I do this or should I do that'"; "I decide myself… my judgment always overrides"	**Human judgment overrides; previous experience rather than intuition**
"In my personal life… I use AI because for example there's a topic I don't know much about and then I follow its instructions much closely"; "I've been using ChatGPT on my weight loss [with] terrific results"; "In work… it's mostly just an advisory tool"	**Context-dependent reliance (personal vs. work)**
"I'm always a bit skeptical because… I'm using it day-to-day and I see how many mistakes it makes even in the easiest of situations" "I try to double-check the data, but overall there is trust"	**Conditional trust and verification**
"A useful contribution for me is a quick and correct analysis of the data I provide to it"; "When it works instantly – as it should in my mind – that is the most useful case scenario"; "Minimum follow-up questions… and it gives you a reply in a very organized and easy to read way… a clean result"	**Ideal AI performance: quick, correct, organized, minimal follow-ups**
"It's easy… you just write a prompt… there are no barriers for me to use AI basically"; "It's mostly technical challenges… the limitations of the AI"; "There are often some bugs… it cannot read a doc or open a CSV file or something breaks"; "The limitations I face… are basically technical"	**Integration ease but technical friction**
"You learn to write the prompts in the best possible way so that it understands you quicker and more accurately"; "You'll spend less time and get more output"; "They're working on new versions all the time – the latest one is 5.1… maybe six comes out in six months and it's… 50% faster"	**Opportunities: prompting literacy, tool evolution**
"I don't have much concerns"; "I'm not a very paranoid person… I don't have any issues with AI using my data, I don't have particularly much to hide"; "I wouldn't want it to turn on us	

and try to kill us, but I'm not… worried about it as much for now"	**Low privacy concern**
"When it gives me the answers I want quickly and reliably… it motivates me to use it more"; "I've been trying to learn how to give better prompts… it first discourages me then it motivates me to find a better way to talk to it"	**Motivation: reliable, fast answers and better prompting**
"You can give a simple task… and then there are still a lot of follow-up questions"; "It tries to look smarter than it is… and overcomplicates stuff"; "When it's acting dumb and it doesn't understand the simplest of prompts"; "The technical bugs it has… it takes five minutes to think about a long line of prompts"; "You rely on it in the moment… it doesn't happen it can be quite frustrating"; "You… waste your time"	**Discouragement: technical failures and prompt churn**
"Could be… done in an Excel… I use it as a more advanced way of doing all that… and then I use my own judgment"	**AI as an advanced Excel-like tool**
"I don't use it for people-related decisions"; "I don't use it as a psychologist… I don't use it as an HR"	**Decision boundaries: avoid people/HR topics**
"I try to limit myself a bit"; "I feel like my brain's becoming slower… because I have all these tools"; "I try not to use it if I'm not rushing… I try to still calculate things… on a piece of paper or… a classic calculator"; "Internal restrictions I set for myself"; "I don't want to keep regressing"; "It is definitely a concern that we… rely more and more on different tools"	**Self-imposed limits to preserve competence, concern about over-reliance**
"If I don't have sufficient knowledge in the area… you connect with someone who does"; "We used… an organizational psychologist… and it worked brilliantly… they were very useful… professional tips coming from a medical doctor"; "I've always thought of my soft skills as my strongest suit and my ability to understand people… I've always considered myself very good at that"	**Preference for human expertise and interpersonal/soft skills**
"Never say never… maybe it's going to be as good as a certified psychologist"; "If AI evolves into being as good as a human being with 15 years of experience in psychology, then why not, but at this point I don't see myself using it now"; "If I feel like it's become really intelligent or even sentient… maybe you can use it a bit more actively and rely on its advice, but in its current state… it's going to be a tool"	**Conditional future openness (capability parity/sentience)**

Appendix D: Mapping of codes to themes (thematic map)

Theme	Codes contributing to theme	Respondents	Regions
AI as a cognitive shortcut under time and information pressure	Time-saving and efficiency (1,2,3); Time-saving strategy (4); Structured framing for efficiency and time reduction (5); Parallel use of AI for multitasking (5); Time-saving as core value (5); Time-saving and quicker overview (6); Time-saving shortcuts (9)	R1, R2, R3, R4, R5, R6, R9	All
AI as an analytical tool for structuring, calculating and understanding data	AI for data analysis (1); Information summarization and search (2); AI for heavy lifting in data tasks (3); AI as scenario generator (3); Data analysis as clear value (4); Role-based prompting for expertise (5); Rule/formula trust (bounded domain certainty) (6); Trust calibrated by task (7); AI as analytical assistant, not a decider (9); AI as an advanced Excel-like tool (9)	R1,R2, R3, R4, R5, R6, R7, R9	All
AI as a 'second opinion'/ sparring partner/decision challenger	AI as sparring partner/decision challenger (1,3); Iterative back-and-forth process (1); Creativity and alternative perspectives (1); AI as a neutral advisor/second opinion (2); Ensuring completeness (4); Useful contribution: new perspectives and reassurance (4); AI as decision-testing tool/occasional sparring partner (4); Useful contribution: support, new perspectives and data analysis (5); AI as decision support and second opinion (6)	R1, R2, R3, R4, R5, R6	1 (North), 2 (Central)

Trust is conditional and fragile; verification is required	Critical review and non-blind trust (1); Task-specific trust (1); Conditional trust and verification (4,9); Challenging AI's answers (5); Task-specific trust and analytical boundaries (factual vs. complex) (6); Verification and plausibility checks (6); Trust trajectory and personalization, trust calibration (6); Trust and accuracy concerns (8)	R1, R4, R5, R6, R8, R9	All
AI's usefulness/reliability depends on the nature of the task (data vs. people)	Ethical boundaries for sensitive decisions (1); Trust in hard data vs. soft topics (2); Trust in AI for data-related decisions (3); Boundaries for human-centric or sensitive decisions (3); Trust in AI for factual/legal topics (4); Boundaries for serious decisions (4); Trust and reliance on AI for analytics and data, not people (5); Occasional use for HR-related numbers, not soft HR (5); Boundaries: high stakes/sensitive decisions (6); Task selection rule (7); Avoids AI for complex or human-centric decisions (8); Numbers-related trust and use cases (9); Decision boundaries: avoid people/HR topics (9)	R1, R2, R3, R4, R5, R6, R7, R8, R9	All
Organisational and technical constraints shape actual adoption	Confidentiality and technical limitations (2); Effort required for complex tasks (4); Current challenge: finding new areas for automation (5); Desire for better integration (8); Integration ease but technical friction (9); Discouragement: technical failures and prompt churn (9)	R2, R4, R5, R8, R9	All

Using AI requires skill: prompting, interpretation and digital competence	Learning curve (1); Training and personalization (1); Need for clear instructions and neutrality (2); Learning curve and prompting skills (3); Integration moderately easy (3); Concern: time to learn and coding skills (3); Discouragement: lack of time for proper prompting (3); Daily use and growing scope (4); Learning agility matters (5); Prompting neutrality and triangulation (6); Prompt borrowing and reuse (7); Personalization using "subjects" (7); Need to steer/focus AI (7); Friction cost to contextualize (7); Iterative prompting burden (7); Curiosity and motivation to learn (7); Prompting challenges (8); Opportunities: prompting literacy and tool evolution (9); Motivation: reliable, fast answers and better prompting (9)	R1, R2, R3, R4, R5, R6, R7, R8, R9	All
The final decision remains human: intuition and experience dominate	Human judgment remains final (1,2); Override when human factors matter (3); Gut feeling as override trigger (3); AI blind spots and red flags (3); AI supporting role, not decision-maker (4); Selective reliance based on experience (4); Decision-making pillars: human judgments first, AI as secondary support (5); Human judgment/intuition overrides (6,7,9); Preparation v.s. decision (7); Process placement (early-stage use) (7): Tacit/local knowledge in staffing (7); Human factors gap (7); Human judgment dominates AI use (8); Post-decision usage of AI (8); Preference for human expertise and interpersonal/soft skills (9)	R1, R2, R3, R4, R5, R6, R7, R8, R9	All